A DOCTORAL THESIS

THE DAUGHTERS OF ATLAS

Parasitic Sovereignty, the Courteous Imperative, and the Sororal Strike in Ken Levine's *BioShock*



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The mind is its own place, and in itself
Can make a Heav'n of Hell, a Hell of Heav'n.

— John Milton, *Paradise Lost* (1667), I.254–255

I do not wish them to have power over men; but over themselves.

— Mary Wollstonecraft, *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (1792), ch. 4

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ABSTRACT

BioShock (Irrational Games, 2007) has been canonized as the medium's most sustained critique of Ayn Rand's Objectivism and as the locus classicus of "ludonarrative dissonance." This thesis argues that both canonical readings, for all their acuity, remain captive to the figure they interrogate: the sovereign, choosing individual, whether as the Randian producer whose ethic Rapture refutes or as the player whose agency the conditioning twist unmasks. Against that horizon, the thesis relocates the work's centre of gravity from the man who chooses to the bodies on which his choosing feeds. Its method is at once constellational and procedural. The game is read beside the extraordinary cluster of texts produced across Rapture's diegetic lifespan (1945–1960), from Sartre's and Heidegger's rival humanisms, the founding of the Mont Pèlerin Society and *Dialectic of Enlightenment* to *The Second Sex*, *The Human Condition*, Isaiah Berlin's "Two Concepts of Liberty" and *Atlas Shrugged* itself, while its reward architecture is analysed as an argument in its own right.

Five claims follow. First, Rapture is not a failed market but a successful parasitic order: its founding relation is not Rand's trader principle of value-for-value but unilateral extraction, condensed in the parasitic sea slug lodged inside conscripted girls (Serres; Locke's servant whose cut turf becomes the master's property; Macpherson's possessive individualism). Second, ADAM's production constitutes a *necro-maternal economy*, an unwaged regime of social reproduction that recycles the dead into value, legible through Federici, Fraser, Irigaray, Rubin and Marx's figure of capital as vampiric dead labour. Third, the conditioning formula is theorized as the *courteous imperative*, a third form beside Kant's categorical and hypothetical imperatives: an utterance whose illocutionary form is a request and whose perlocutionary force is compulsion, and which therefore condenses, with philological exactitude, Carole Pateman's thesis that contract is the modern instrument of subordination. Fourth, the game's procedural economy, in which mercy is compensated and virtue pays, constitutes a *ludic Objectivism* that silently ratifies Rand's doctrine of the harmony of rational interests even as the narrative indicts it; the celebrated dissonance is accordingly reconceived as complicity. Fifth, the single act in *BioShock* that escapes both Rapture's economy and the player's agency, namely the Little Sisters' collective killing of Frank Fontaine, the counterfeit "Atlas," an event invariant across every ending and withheld from interactive control, is theorized as a *sororal strike*: the inversion of the producers' strike in *Atlas Shrugged* (a novel drafted under the working title *The Strike*), which answers that

novel's founding question by naming the world's true bearers. They are not the industrialist-Titans. They are the daughters.

The thesis concludes that *BioShock* is a feminist text written against its own paternalist frame. Its moral system can conceive the girls only as objects of paternal decision, harvested or rescued, yet its structure concedes them the final act. That act is also the only testimony the girls are permitted: conditioned to describe their exploitation solely in their exploiters' vocabulary, a condition the thesis analyses as engineered hermeneutical injustice, they speak once, in a deed without words. Drawing on Wollstonecraft, Beauvoir, Weil, Arendt, Spivak, Hartman, Haraway and Wynter, it proposes a relational, sororal humanism as the horizon that the game glimpses but cannot render playable.

A NOTE ON CITATION

Corpus, Authorship, and Paraphrastic Citation

The primary text is *BioShock* (2007). *BioShock 2* (2K Marin, 2010; creative direction by Jordan Thomas), *BioShock Infinite* (Irrational Games, 2013) and the two-part *Burial at Sea* (2013–2014) are treated as comparative paratexts, not as evidence for the first game's meanings. "Levine" names the creative direction of a large studio, not a solitary author; the attribution is a metonym for collective authorship, and every claim about intention is subordinated to claims about the work.

The game's language is cited paraphrastically. Its speech is dispersed across recorded media (audio diaries, shortwave transmissions, public-address announcements, signage, advertising jingles, cinematics), and the evidentiary status of those media is itself an object of analysis in Chapter III. Utterances are therefore restated in the analyst's own words and located by district and diegetic medium, for example (*BioShock*, Medical Pavilion; audio diary). Paraphrase obliges the interpretation to carry its own weight and respects the integrity of the work. One exception is made: the three-word conditioning formula *would you kindly* is treated as a term of art, much as philosophy treats *cogito* or *Dasein*, because the argument of Chapter III depends on its grammar.

Modern theory is likewise paraphrased and cited author-date. Texts first published before 1929 are occasionally quoted from public-domain editions or translations (the Authorized Version of Genesis, Jowett's Aristotle, the Moore–Aveling *Capital*, Milton, Locke, Wollstonecraft, Shelley). Classical and early-modern texts are cited by standard divisions: Stephanus pages for Plato, Bekker numbers for Aristotle, section numbers for Locke, book and line for Milton.

Diegetic chronology follows the game: Rapture is built in the mid-1940s and opened in 1946; Fontaine's apparent death and the outbreak of civil war on New Year's Eve occur in 1958; Jack arrives in 1960.



Rapture as Problem

The Descent

BioShock begins with a fall and then a descent. An airliner breaks apart on the North Atlantic; its sole survivor swims to a lighthouse whose interior displays, beneath a colossal bust of the city's founder, a banner that negates gods and kings in favour of Man alone. A bathysphere carries him down through black water while a recorded voice, belonging to a man he has not yet seen, poses the question on which the city below was founded: to whom does the product of a man's labour belong? Three claimants are dismissed in turn. Washington takes it as tax, the Vatican as tithe, Moscow as the share of all. Against them the voice sets a fourth possibility, a city in which the artist need not fear the censor, the scientist need not answer to conventional morality, and exceptional individuals would no longer be held back by ordinary ones; the window of the bathysphere then opens on its realization (*BioShock*, Welcome to Rapture; cinematic).

The triad is not incidental. It reproduces, almost diagrammatically, the demonology of Rand's "For the New Intellectual" (1961), in which the producer is expropriated by two parasitic archetypes, "Attila," the man of force, and "the Witch Doctor," the man of faith, whose alliance Rand discerned in every collectivism. Washington is Attila, the Vatican the Witch Doctor, Moscow their marriage. Rapture is accordingly a counterfactual conducted in architecture: what if Galt's Gulch, the hidden valley to which the producers of *Atlas Shrugged* withdraw, had been built, populated and left to

run? Because a videogame is, in Jesper Juul's formulation, half-real, a fiction wrapped around rules that genuinely operate (Juul 2005), the counterfactual is not merely depicted. It is executed.

Two Paradigms and Their Shared Presupposition

Scholarship has organized itself around two paradigms. The first, which may be called the *ideology-critique paradigm*, reads Rapture as a *reductio* of Objectivism: an egoist polity, once supplied with an unregulated market in self-modification, collapses into a Hobbesian war of all against all and then into the very despotism it was built to escape (Packer 2010; the essays in Cuddy 2015). Objectivist commentators have replied that Rapture lacks the institutional furniture Rand's politics require, namely objective law, courts and a state monopoly on retaliatory force, so that its fall refutes anarcho-capitalism rather than Objectivism. The rejoinder is not trivial, and Chapter I takes it seriously. Yet critique and rejoinder share a question: can the sovereign individual govern himself?

The second, the *agency-critique paradigm*, begins from Clint Hocking's 2007 diagnosis of "ludonarrative dissonance": the game's mechanics reward the very self-interest its story condemns, while its story compels an obedience its mechanics appear to have abolished (Hocking 2007). Grant Tavinor locates the work's artistic achievement in the reflexive exposure of that obedience (Tavinor 2009); Ian Bogost's account of procedural rhetoric supplies the general theory by which rules argue (Bogost 2007); Miguel Sicart's ethics of play sharpens the suspicion that choice systems translate deliberation into arithmetic (Sicart 2009). The second paradigm's question is: was the player ever free?

The paradigms disagree about everything except their protagonist. Each takes the *chooser*, whether Ryan founding, Jack obeying or the player deciding, as the bearer of the work's meaning. In both, the Little Sisters appear chiefly as the material of a dilemma, the occasion on which someone else's freedom is exercised or exposed. This structure has a precise name in feminist political theory. Carole Pateman showed that the classical story of the social contract, in which free individuals covenant as equals, presupposes and conceals a prior *sexual contract* that secures men's access to women's bodies and labour (Pateman 1988). The story of free choosers, in other words, is told over a substrate that it does not narrate. This thesis proposes to narrate it.

Who Is Atlas?

Rand's novel turns on a refrain of exhausted bafflement, an interrogation of John Galt's identity that recurs until Galt reveals himself as the organizer of the producers' strike. *BioShock* transfers the interrogation to its counterfeit revolutionary, the brogue-voiced "Atlas" who guides Jack by shortwave and who is unmasked as the gangster-entrepreneur Frank Fontaine. The name carries more than Rand. In Hesiod,

Atlas is the Titan condemned to hold up the sky; in Plato's *Critias* (114a–c), Atlas is the first king of Atlantis, the eldest son of Poseidon, after whom both the island and the surrounding Atlantic are named; in later mythography his daughters include the Hesperides, who guard the golden apples in a garden at the western edge of the world, and Calypso, the sea-nymph who detains Odysseus with the promise of immortality. A sunken city in the Atlantic, governed by a man posing as Atlas, sustained by girls who tend a substance named for the first man of Eden: the mythographic overdetermination is close to total.

This thesis answers the question literally. In Rand, Atlas is the industrialist who bears the world and whose shrug would let it fall. In *BioShock*, the one who actually bears Rapture, whose body produces the substance on which every citizen's self-making depends, is a Little Sister. Atlas is a little girl. The rest of the argument is an attempt to show what follows when that sentence is taken seriously.

Method: A Descent in Three Stages

The method takes its form from the game's opening and from a passage in the first volume of *Capital*. Marx invites his reader to leave the noisy sphere of circulation, which he calls "a very Eden of the innate rights of man," where "Freedom, Equality, Property and Bentham" alone appear to rule, and to descend into "the hidden abode of production" (Marx [1867] 1887, ch. 6). Nancy Fraser has argued that the descent must go one level further, behind the hidden abode, to the unwaged social reproduction, natural substrate and political power on which production silently depends (Fraser 2014; 2022). *BioShock*'s Edenic nomenclature makes the first stage almost embarrassingly literal: ADAM and EVE are sold from vending machines in a city whose public rhetoric is entirely a rhetoric of rights. The thesis therefore descends in three stages, from Rapture's ideology of rights (Chapters I–III) to its regime of production (Chapter IV) and finally to the reproductive and procedural substrate beneath both (Chapters V–VIII).

The historical method is constellational in the sense developed by Walter Benjamin and Theodor Adorno: elements from different domains are juxtaposed so that each illuminates the others, without any claim of direct causation. Rapture's diegetic lifespan coincides with an unusually dense moment in the history of Western thought about freedom, humanity, sex and the market. The table below assembles that constellation; Rapture's own events are marked as diegetic.

YEAR	RAPTURE (DIEGETIC)	PHILOSOPHY AND THEORY	LITERATURE, SCIENCE, POLITICS
1944	—	Hayek, *The Road to Serfdom*; Horkheimer and Adorno circulate *Philosophische Fragmente*	—

YEAR	RAPTURE (DIEGETIC)	PHILOSOPHY AND THEORY	LITERATURE, SCIENCE, POLITICS
1945	Construction begins	Popper, *The Open Society and Its Enemies*; Sartre lectures on existentialism as a humanism	Weil's essay on the *Iliad* as a poem of force appears in English
1946	The city opens	Sartre's lecture published; Heidegger drafts the "Letter on Humanism"; Julian Huxley drafts UNESCO's founding philosophy, urging that eugenics remain thinkable	Trenet records "La Mer"
1947	—	Mont Pèlerin Society founded; *Dialectic of Enlightenment* published; Beauvoir, *The Ethics of Ambiguity*	Primo Levi, *If This Is a Man*
1948	—	Skinner, *Walden Two*	Universal Declaration of Human Rights adopted
1949	—	Beauvoir, *The Second Sex*; Lévi-Strauss, *Elementary Structures of Kinship*; Bataille, *The Accursed Share*; Mises, *Human Action*; Weil, *The Need for Roots* (posthumous)	Orwell, *Nineteen Eighty-Four*; Chandler, *The Little Sister*
1951	—	Arendt, *The Origins of Totalitarianism*	Hunter, *Brain-Washing in Red China*; Carson, *The Sea Around Us*
1953	—	Skinner, *Science and Human Behavior*	Watson and Crick publish the double helix, built on Franklin's data; Cousteau's *The Silent World* popularizes "rapture of the deep"; MKUltra begins
1955	—	—	Williams, *Cat on a Hot Tin Roof*, whose patriarch is Big Daddy
1957	—	Rand, *Atlas Shrugged*; Julian Huxley's essay "Transhumanism"; Sargant, *Battle for the Mind*	Packard, *The Hidden Persuaders*; Sputnik
1958	Fontaine's apparent death; civil war from New Year's Eve	Arendt, *The Human Condition*; Berlin, "Two Concepts of Liberty"; Galbraith, *The Affluent Society*	—
1959	Ryan's emergency rule	Julian Huxley begins his presidency of the Eugenics Society	Condon, *The Manchurian Candidate*
1960	Jack arrives	Hayek, *The Constitution of Liberty*	The FDA approves the first oral contraceptive
1961–63	—	Lifton, *Thought Reform* (1961); Fanon, *The Wretched of the Earth* (1961); Macpherson, *Possessive Individualism* (1962); Arendt, *Eichmann in Jerusalem* (1963)	Carson, *Silent Spring* (1962); Friedan, *The Feminine Mystique* (1963)

The constellation discloses a structure invisible from inside any single discipline. In the same fifteen years, neoliberalism found its institutional home, existentialism and its critics fought over the word *humanism*, feminist philosophy acquired its founding treatise, behaviourism promised the engineering of conduct, molecular biology located life in a code, the postwar settlement sent the women of the war factories back into the home, and eugenics survived the war in the founding documents of postwar humanism. Rapture is the place where these lines cross.

The formal method follows Bogost (2007) and Galloway (2006): rules are read as arguments, and play as an allegory of the control it simulates. The philological method treats names as condensations in Freud's sense, sites where several chains of association converge. Both serve the political-economic method, which asks of every relation in Rapture who gives, who takes, and who is not counted.

Theses and Conceptual Apparatus

The argument advances five theses, stated in the Abstract, and develops a small vocabulary to carry them.

CONCEPT	DEFINITION	PRINCIPAL INTERLOCUTORS	CHAPTER
Parasitic sovereignty	Self-ownership that exists only by feeding on a host denied subjecthood	Serres, Locke, Macpherson, Pateman	I, IV
The onomastic confession	Rapture's names avow the impossibility of the order they designate	Nietzsche, Adorno and Horkheimer, Agamben	II
The courteous imperative	A command in the grammatical form of a request; consent as the form of compulsion	Austin, Searle, Kant, Althusser, Pateman	III
The acousmatic sovereign	Power exercised as a disembodied voice, broken when the voice acquires a body	Chion, Dolar, Silverman	III
The necro-maternal economy	Value produced by conscripted girls who recycle the dead through their bodies	Marx, Federici, Fraser, Irigaray, Rubin	IV
The paper-knife subject	A person whose essence was fixed before his existence began	Sartre, Habermas, Arendt	VI
Ludic Objectivism	Reward architecture as a value-for-value economy that ratifies Rand's harmony of interests	Rand, Kant, Hocking, Bogost	VII
Engineered hermeneutical injustice	Conditioning that supplies a system's victims only concepts that render their victimization unintelligible	Fricker, Spivak, Hartman	VIII
The sororal strike	The withdrawal and insurrection of reproductive labour against the counterfeit Atlas	Federici, Benjamin, Le Guin, Haraway	VIII

Architecture of the Argument

Chapter I reconstructs the genealogy of Rapture's sovereign self from Locke, against Filmer, through Stirner, Nietzsche, Rand and Berlin, and isolates the parasitic clause that this genealogy carries from its origin. Chapter II reads the city's nomenclature as a confession that enlightenment has reverted to myth. Chapter III analyses the conditioning formula as the grammar of liberal power. Chapter IV descends into the economy of ADAM. Chapter V turns to Rapture's women, girls and protector-men through the major texts of feminist theory and fiction. Chapter VI situates the game within the long argument over humanism, from Pico della Mirandola to Sylvia Wynter, and within the eugenic tradition that runs from Galton through the camps to the liberal enhancement debate. Chapter VII returns to the player and argues that the game's form is more Randian than its content is anti-Randian. Chapter VIII assembles the original thesis, the sororal strike, and confronts both the girls' silence in the game's archive and the ethics of representing what was done to them; the Coda follows the series' daughters toward authorship.

CHAPTER I

I

Genealogies of the Sovereign Self

Rand, Nietzsche, Stirner, Locke

Rapture's founding ideology is not a caricature of Objectivism but a faithful dramatization of a tradition whose fine print it reads more closely than its admirers do. That fine print is a parasitic clause: from Locke onward, the self-owning individual has been defined in a way that silently counts the labour of others as his own. This chapter reconstructs the genealogy and isolates the clause.

I.1 The System and Its Wager

Alisa Zinovyevna Rosenbaum was born in St Petersburg in 1905, watched the Bolsheviks confiscate her father's pharmacy, emigrated in 1926 and remade herself in America as Ayn Rand (Heller 2009; Burns 2009). *The Fountainhead* (1943) and *Atlas Shrugged* (1957) delivered, in the form of the romantic novel, a philosophy she later systematized as Objectivism. Its five branches can be stated briefly. In metaphysics, reality exists independently of consciousness and obeys the law of identity, the Aristotelian axiom that the third part of *Atlas Shrugged* takes as its title, "A is A." In epistemology, reason is the sole means of knowledge, and concepts are formed by measurement-omission from perceived particulars (Rand 1966–67). In ethics, the individual's own life is the standard of value and rational self-interest the only virtue; altruism, understood as the doctrine that self-sacrifice is the moral ideal, is the root of tyranny (Rand 1964). In politics, the only legitimate social system is laissez-faire capitalism, and government is confined to the police, the courts and the military, which secure individuals against the initiation of force. In aesthetics, art is a selective

re-creation of reality according to the artist's fundamental value-judgements, and its highest form is a Romantic Realism that depicts man as he might and ought to be (Rand 1969).

The ethics rests on a wager that *BioShock* puts to the test. Rand held that among rational agents there are no genuine conflicts of interest: the trader principle, the exchange of value for value by mutual consent, ensures that no one's gain requires another's sacrifice (Rand 1964, "The 'Conflicts' of Men's Interests"). Everything in her politics depends on this harmony. If rational interests can conflict, then a society of rational egoists requires an arbiter whose authority does not derive from trade, and the minimal state ceases to be minimal. Rapture is the experiment that removes the arbiter and watches what the harmony does without one.

I.2 Ryan as Rand: Biography, Rhetoric, and the Right to Destroy

Andrew Ryan's name is a near-anagram of his model's, and his biography is hers in masculine translation: a Russian-born émigré who fled the revolution, built an industrial empire in America and came to regard every claim upon a producer's wealth as theft. His lexicon is Rand's. The epithet he reaches for most often is *parasite*, the category in which *Atlas Shrugged* places looters and moochers alike.

The most revealing episode in Ryan's biography is preserved in an audio diary in Arcadia, the city's arboreal oxygen garden. Before founding Rapture, Ryan bought a tract of forest; when the government moved to make it a public park, he burned it rather than surrender it (*BioShock*, Arcadia; audio diary). Roman law divided ownership into *usus*, *fructus* and *abusus*, the rights to use, to enjoy the fruits and to consume or destroy. Ryan's fire exercises the third, and it exercises it as an assertion of sovereignty against the state. Marcel Mauss's potlatch, in which a chief destroys wealth to demonstrate a standing that no rival can match, and Georges Bataille's theory of sovereignty as useless expenditure are the anthropological frames for the gesture (Mauss [1925]; Bataille [1949] 1988). The burned forest is a prophecy in miniature. Ryan will later exercise *abusus* on his city and finally on himself.

Ryan's trajectory after 1958 is the empirical heart of the ideology-critique paradigm. Faced with Fontaine's black market and Atlas's insurrection, the founder of a city without kings nationalizes Fontaine Futuristics, publicly executes smugglers, forbids contact with the surface and, in the game's late revelations, resorts to chemical control of the spliced population. The libertarian sovereign becomes the Schmittian one, he who decides on the exception (Schmitt [1922] 1985). Karl Popper, writing in the year Rapture's construction began, had warned that utopian engineering, the attempt to realize a blueprint of the ideal society as a whole, requires a centralized power strong enough to suppress dissent from the blueprint, and therefore ends in dictatorship (Popper 1945). That Popper was a founding member of the Mont Pèlerin Society, and

that his critique applies here to a libertarian blueprint, is the first of many ironies the constellation reveals.

The Objectivist rejoinder holds that Rapture lacks objective law, so its collapse proves nothing about Rand. The rejoinder misidentifies what the game removes. Rapture lacks a *neutral* arbiter because its founder owns the city. Every lease, every bathysphere, every genetic lock and every public utility belongs to Ryan. Morris Cohen argued in 1927 that property in the means of life is a form of sovereignty, since the owner's power to exclude is a power to command those who need what he owns (Cohen 1927). In Rapture, *dominium* and *imperium* coincide without remainder: the landlord is the state. The minimal state was never absent. It was privatized, and a privatized sovereign cannot be neutral in any dispute, because he is a party to all of them.

Rapture's founding act also contains a contradiction that the political theory of exit makes precise. Ryan founds the city by leaving: he exercises what Albert Hirschman called *exit* against the voice-based politics of the surface (Hirschman 1970). Robert Nozick's libertarian "framework for utopia" presupposes that every community permits its members to leave (Nozick 1974, Part III). Rapture forbids it, and treats the smuggling of goods and persons across its boundary as a capital crime. The founding freedom is reserved to the founder. Peter Thiel's 2009 essay announcing that he no longer believed freedom and democracy compatible, and recommending escape into cyberspace, outer space and the sea, shows how directly the fantasy survived the game that anatomized it (Thiel 2009).

I.3 The Nietzschean Undertow

Rand's early notebooks are saturated with Nietzsche. She planned to open *The Fountainhead* with an aphorism from *Beyond Good and Evil* on the noble soul's reverence for itself, removed it before publication, and in her 1968 introduction to the novel's anniversary edition explained that Nietzsche, for all his heroic sense of life, was a mystic and an irrationalist (Burns 2009; Sciabarra 1995). Objectivism is in part a domestication of Nietzsche: the Übermensch is translated into the industrialist, master morality into the ethics of trade, and the will to power into the productive mind.

The domestication is unstable, and *BioShock* lets it come apart. Nietzsche despised precisely the merchant ethos into which Rand translated him; the "aristocratic radicalism" Georg Brandes ascribed to him has no place for the shopkeeper (Brandes 1889). More importantly, Nietzschean self-overcoming is an *askesis*, a discipline of the self that takes a lifetime. Peter Sloterdijk's reconstruction of the anthropotechnic tradition emphasizes exactly this: the human being becomes more than it is only through practice, through the vertical tension of exercise (Sloterdijk 2013). The plasmid abolishes practice. ADAM sells self-overcoming as a product, and what it yields is

neither Übermensch nor master but the two figures Nietzsche feared most: the last man, who seeks comfort and novelty, and the beast. The splicer is both.

I.4 Stirner and the Spook of Man

The lighthouse banner, which banishes gods and kings and enthrones Man, belongs to a precise moment in the history of philosophy. In *The Essence of Christianity* (1841), Ludwig Feuerbach argued that God is the projected essence of humanity and that theology is secretly anthropology; the task was to reclaim for Man the predicates alienated to God. Three years later Max Stirner replied that Feuerbach had merely changed the name of the deity. "Man," the universal essence before which the individual must bow, was a *Spuk*, a spook, as tyrannical as the God it replaced; the only reality was the unique individual and whatever he could make his own (Stirner [1844]).

Rapture stages the quarrel between Feuerbach and Stirner as the quarrel between Ryan and Fontaine. Ryan is a Feuerbachian moralist: he has dethroned God only to enthrone Man, and he binds his citizens with rules, rights and contracts that are, in Stirner's terms, spooks. Fontaine is the consistent egoist. He keeps no faith with any principle, recognizes property only as what he can seize, and treats Ryan's rights as a sentimental fiction. If self-interest is the only virtue, the con man is the most virtuous man in Rapture, and Fontaine's victory over Ryan is not the defeat of egoism but its completion. The banner's "Man" meets the fate Stirner predicted. Worshipped, it splits into the beast (the splicer) and the god (Fontaine's final, gilded, Titan-like form).

I.5 Locke, Macpherson, and the Parasitic Clause

Ryan's founding question, whether a man is entitled to what his labour produces, reaches back past Rand to the Bible. In the Authorized Version, the curse that expels Adam from Eden reads: "In the sweat of thy face shalt thou eat bread" (Genesis 3:19). Labour begins as punishment. John Locke converted the curse into a title. "Every man has a property in his own person," he wrote, and whatever he removes from the common state of nature and mixes with his labour becomes his own (Locke [1689], Second Treatise §27). Ryan converts the title into a sacrament.

The next section of the *Second Treatise* contains the clause on which this thesis turns. Locke illustrates appropriation with a list: "the grass my horse has bit; the turfs my servant has cut; and the ore I have digged" all become "my property" (§28). The servant's labour is the master's property, and Locke does not pause over it. The self-owning individual is constituted, from the first, by counting another's labour as his own. C. B. Macpherson named the resulting conception *possessive individualism*: the individual as sole proprietor of his person and capacities, owing nothing to society for them, and society as a set of exchanges among proprietors (Macpherson 1962). Pateman

showed that the fiction of "property in the person" is what allows a relation of subordination, whether in employment, marriage or the surrogacy contract, to be represented as a free exchange between equals (Pateman 1988). G. A. Cohen showed that self-ownership, taken strictly, cannot be reconciled with any robust equality of condition (Cohen 1995).

Rapture's economy is Locke's §28 enlarged into a civilization. The turfs are cut by girls. ADAM is harvested by Little Sisters and becomes the property of whoever controls them: Fontaine, then Ryan, then any splicer or player who can take it. The city's protagonist, moreover, is the limit case that the self-ownership thesis cannot even formulate. Jack was purchased as an embryo, accelerated, conditioned and shipped to the surface as an asset. He was property before he was a person. To ask whether Jack owns himself is to ask a question that the doctrine of property in the person cannot answer, because the doctrine assumes that the person precedes the property.

The city's operating system exposes a second clause. Ryan secures Rapture's bathyspheres and critical machinery with genetic locks keyed to his own DNA, so that only his blood can operate them; Jack can pass because he is Ryan's son. The meritocracy of producers is unlocked by lineage. Sociology distinguishes achieved status, earned by performance, from ascribed status, assigned at birth (Linton 1936), and Rand's novels reserve their deepest contempt for the ascribed: James Taggart inherits a railroad he cannot run, and Philip Rearden lives on his brother's fortune. Rapture's machinery honours only ascription. The irony has a precise pedigree. Locke wrote the First Treatise of Government to demolish Robert Filmer's *Patriarcha* (1680), which derived the authority of kings from the dominion God gave Adam, transmitted from father to son down the generations. Locke replaced inherited dominion with self-ownership and consent. Ryan's city speaks Locke and locks Filmer: authority descends by blood from the man whose city sells a substance called ADAM to the son who inherits his genetic key. Pateman argued that the social contract overthrew the father's political right while preserving men's patriarchal right in other forms (Pateman 1988). In Rapture the father's right survives in the doors themselves. And because the heir was purchased, conditioned and delivered as an asset, inheritance and property fuse completely: the son inherits the father's dominion and is himself someone else's property.

I.6 The Synchrony of Retreats

Rapture opens in 1946. In April 1947, Friedrich Hayek convened thirty-nine economists, historians and philosophers at Mont Pèlerin, above Lake Geneva, to found the society that historians now regard as the institutional origin of neoliberalism (Mirowski and Plehwe 2009). The two foundings mirror each other. Each is a retreat of the elect from a world they believed was drowning in collectivism, one to a mountain and one to the seabed, and each conceives itself as an ark. Rand despised Hayek's compromises with

the welfare state (Burns 2009), and Rapture is closer to her intransigence than to his caution. Yet Hayek's argument in *The Road to Serfdom* (1944), that planning leads inexorably to servitude, finds in Rapture its mirror image: the abolition of planning produces a serfdom of its own, whose serfs are a conditioned man and a population of conscripted girls. Hayek's *The Constitution of Liberty* appeared in 1960, the year Jack's plane fell.

I.7 Two Concepts of Liberty Under the Sea

Isaiah Berlin delivered his inaugural lecture at Oxford, "Two Concepts of Liberty," on 31 October 1958, two months before the New Year's Eve attack that began Rapture's civil war. Berlin distinguished negative liberty, the area within which a person is left alone by others, from positive liberty, the freedom of self-mastery, of being governed by one's rational or "true" self. He argued that positive liberty, though noble in origin, carries a characteristic danger: once the self is divided into a higher and a lower part, the higher can be identified with a collective, a party or a ruler, who may then coerce individuals in the name of the freedom they would choose if they were rational (Berlin 1958).

Rapture runs through both concepts and both of their dangers. Ryan's founding is negative liberty absolutized: no state, no church, no collective claim on the producer. Atlas speaks the language of positive liberty, a populist promise to raise the city's poor to a dignity they cannot yet secure for themselves, and the promise is a mask for Fontaine's mastery of them. Ryan's end completes Berlin's warning from the opposite pole. The champion of negative liberty, facing a population he believes has chosen irrationally, resorts to chemical control of the splicers, compelling them, in effect, to act as their rational selves would have acted had they not been corrupted. The man who built a city in order to be left alone ends by governing his citizens' nervous systems. Berlin predicted that positive liberty would be the road to coercion; Rapture shows the road running from the negative pole as well. What decides the outcome is less the conception of liberty than the presence of a sovereign who believes he knows what the free would choose. In the terms of Chapter III, both conceptions end in the courteous imperative: power that speaks in the voice of the subject's own will.

I.8 Conclusion: Reading the Fine Print

The critique of Objectivism that *BioShock* mounts is often dismissed as an attack on a straw man. The genealogy shows the reverse. The game reads the tradition's fine print: the servant in Locke's §28, the spook in Feuerbach's Man, the askesis Rand removed from Nietzsche, the sovereignty concealed in ownership, the exit reserved to the founder, the blood that opens the doors, the true self in whose name liberty is

withdrawn. Each of these is a place where the sovereign self depends on something it does not acknowledge. The next chapter shows that Rapture's names already know this.

CHAPTER II

II

The Onomastics of Ecstasy

Rapture, Atlas, ADAM, and the Reversion of Enlightenment to Myth

Rapture's names confess what its founder denies. Every major name in the city, beginning with its own, designates the loss of self-possession, the fall of an overreaching order, or the seizure of one body by another. This chapter reads that nomenclature as a condensation in Freud's sense and argues that it amounts to an *onomastic confession*: the city of the self-owning individual is named, at every level, for the condition of being owned.

II.1 "Rapture": Five Ecstasies

The word carries at least five senses, and each names a dissolution of the bounded, sovereign self.

The first is eschatological. In the dispensationalist theology systematized by John Nelson Darby in the 1830s, the Rapture is the moment at which the elect are snatched from a doomed world before its tribulation, on the authority of Paul's promise that the living faithful "shall be caught up together with them in the clouds" (1 Thessalonians 4:17). Ryan's city is a secular rapture of the elect producers, removed from a world he believed was sliding toward collectivist ruin. But the trajectory is inverted. The elect are not caught up; they go down. The Christian rapture is an *anabasis*, Ryan's a *katabasis*, a descent into the underworld that classical epic reserves for heroes who must consult the dead. That *BioShock* was conceived while the *Left Behind* novels (1995–2007) were making dispensationalist eschatology a mass-market genre in the United States sharpens the irony.

The second is Dionysian. In *The Birth of Tragedy* (1872), Nietzsche opposes two artistic drives: the Apollonian, the dream of form and measure that sustains the *principium individuationis*, the principle of individuation he borrows from Schopenhauer, and the Dionysian, an intoxicated ecstasy in which the boundaries of the individual dissolve into a collective, bodily union. Nietzsche's word for that intoxication is *Rausch*, which he later made the physiological precondition of all art (*Twilight of the Idols*, 1889). In David Farrell Krell's translation of Heidegger's lectures on Nietzsche, *Rausch* is rendered precisely as "rapture" (Heidegger 1979). Rapture's Art Deco is an Apollonian architecture: geometry, gilding, sculpted gods, the monument of the individual. Its population becomes Dionysian: masked, intoxicated, dissolved into a swarm. The city built to enshrine the principle of individuation is named for the state that abolishes it.

The third is narcotic. "Rapture of the deep" is the divers' name for nitrogen narcosis, the euphoria and loss of judgement that pressure induces at depth; Jacques-Yves Cousteau's *The Silent World* (1953) made the English phrase famous, rendering the French *l'ivresse des grandes profondeurs*. A city consecrated to reason is named for the intoxication that depth inflicts on reason. ADAM addiction is the social form of that narcosis.

The fourth is mystical and erotic. Rapture is ecstasy, *ek-stasis*, standing outside oneself, the condition Bernini sculpted in Teresa of Ávila's transverberation (1647–52). The mystic in rapture is not self-possessed; she is possessed.

The fifth sense is etymological, and it is the most damning. "Rapture" descends from Latin *raptus*, the past participle of *rapere*: to seize, to carry off, to abduct. The same root gives "rape," in its older sense of abduction, and Roman historiography placed such an abduction at the origin of the city itself. In Livy's account, Romulus's Rome, a city of men without women, secured its future by seizing the daughters of the Sabines at a festival (Livy 1.9–13). A city that cannot reproduce itself takes the bodies it needs. Rapture's economy rests on the same founding act: girls gathered from Fontaine's orphanage and the city's poorest families, conditioned and implanted to reproduce the substance on which the city lives. The name contains the abduction. This is the onomastic confession in its purest form.

II.2 Atlas, Atlantis, and Utopia

Plato's Atlantis was a maritime empire of extraordinary wealth and technical splendour, ruled by the descendants of Poseidon through his eldest son Atlas, whose kings grew arrogant as the divine element in them diminished and who were swallowed by the sea in a single day and night (*Timaeus* 24e–25d; *Critias* 113c–121c). Rapture begins where Atlantis ends: already under the water. Francis Bacon's *New Atlantis* (1627) refounded the myth as a utopia of research. Its institution, Salomon's House, declares its end to be "the knowledge of Causes, and secret motions of things;

and the enlarging of the bounds of Human Empire, to the effecting of all things possible." Fontaine Futuristics, at Point Prometheus, is Salomon's House privatized: knowledge for the enlargement not of human empire but of a single owner's market share.

Fontaine's choice of alias is therefore exact. The Titan bears; the con man is borne. Rand's figure of Atlas carries the world on the strength of his productive mind; Fontaine's Atlas carries nothing and rides on everyone. In the final confrontation he splices himself into a gilded, statuesque giant who recalls the bronze Atlas that Lee Lawrie and Rene Chambellan installed at Rockefeller Center in 1937, the Art Deco icon that a generation of Rand's readers took as the emblem of her novel. And Atlas, in the mythographic tradition, has daughters: the Hesperides, who guard the golden apples of immortality in a garden at the western edge of the world, and Calypso, the sea-nymph who holds Odysseus on her island with the offer of an endless life (*Odyssey* 1.52). The guardians of the Edenic fruit, at the western ocean, are the daughters of Atlas. Chapter VIII takes them at their word.

The genre's own name is a pun on place. Thomas More's *Utopia* (1516) joined the Greek *ou-topos*, no-place, to *eu-topos*, good-place, and entrusted its account of an island republic without private property to a narrator, Raphael Hythloday, whose surname suggests a peddler of nonsense. Rapture is More inverted. Property is absolute rather than abolished, and the city is literally a no-place, absent from every map and hidden beneath the sea, that claims to be the good place.

The tradition More named has a constant that Rapture inherits: from its Platonic origin, utopia has secured its perfection by seizing control of reproduction. In Book V of the *Republic*, Plato's guardians are paired by rigged lotteries so that the best will reproduce with the best, and their children are raised in common, ignorant of their parents. Tommaso Campanella's *City of the Sun* (written 1602) gave magistrates the authority to pair citizens by physical constitution for the good of the commonwealth. Gilman's Herland, as Chapter V shows, perfects its population by suppressing the reproduction of those it deems unfit, and Huxley's hatcheries, discussed in Chapter VI, decant their citizens to order. The dystopian turn kept the constant and reversed its valuation. Yevgeny Zamyatin's *We* (written 1920–21, first published in English in 1924) imagines a One State of glass apartments and numbered citizens, in which motherhood is permitted only to women who meet a Maternal Norm and whose final remedy for unrest is an operation that excises the imagination. In Orwell's *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (1949), the Party turns children into informers against their own parents. Rapture belongs to this lineage while claiming to have abolished all collective planning. It does not end the utopian seizure of reproduction and of children. It privatizes it, replacing Plato's guardians and Campanella's magistrates with an entrepreneur, his orphanage and his market.

II.3 Eden: ADAM, EVE, and the Gender of Matter

The serpent's promise in Genesis is the promise of ADAM: "ye shall be as gods, knowing good and evil" (Genesis 3:5). A city that banishes the gods sells, by the syringe, the means of becoming one. Renaissance humanism had already read Genesis this way. In Giovanni Pico della Mirandola's *Oration on the Dignity of Man* (1486), God addresses Adam as a being without fixed place or form, free to sink to the level of the brutes or rise toward the divine by his own choosing. Pico's Adam is the founding figure of what Stephen Greenblatt called self-fashioning (Greenblatt 1980). Rapture commodifies Pico. Self-fashioning arrives in a vial, and the splicers demonstrate both of Pico's possibilities at once, ascending to powers once reserved for gods while descending, bodily and morally, to the beast.

The nomenclature is gendered with a precision that has received little notice. ADAM is the structural substance. It rewrites the genome, confers permanent capacities, and functions as capital. EVE is the consumable. It powers plasmids, is spent with every use, and must be endlessly replenished from hypodermics bought at vending machines. The masculine principle is form; the feminine is fuel. This reproduces the oldest metaphysics of sexual difference in the Western canon: in Aristotle's *Generation of Animals*, the male contributes form and the principle of motion, the female only the matter that receives them (729a–b). Luce Irigaray's *Speculum of the Other Woman* (1974) traced how this division casts woman as the matrix, *mater* and matter, on which the masculine economy of the same inscribes its forms. *BioShock* completes the figure. The substance named for the first man is produced in the bodies of girls. The matrix makes the form, and the form takes the name.

Nietzsche had already gendered the two myths that Rapture places side by side. In section 9 of *The Birth of Tragedy* he contrasts the Promethean myth, in which humanity acquires fire through an active, noble sacrilege, with the Semitic myth of the Fall, which he attributes to a series of predominantly feminine affects: curiosity, deception, susceptibility to seduction, lust. Rapture contains both. Its research district is Point Prometheus; its substances are ADAM and EVE; its plasmid vending machine is the Gatherer's Garden. And Marx's ironic description of the sphere of market exchange as "a very Eden of the innate rights of man" (Marx [1867] 1887, ch. 6) acquires a vending slot.

II.4 Pantheon and Pandemonium

The districts compose a pantheon in ruins. Apollo Square, named for the god of light, order and measure, houses Fontaine's poorhouses and becomes Atlas's insurgent base: the Apollonian in its slum. Neptune's Bounty, the fishery, honours the god whom Plato made the father of Atlas. Olympus Heights houses the elite in apartments named for the

home of the gods, at the bottom of the sea. Arcadia, the pastoral garden that oxygenates the city, recalls the motto of Poussin's shepherds, *Et in Arcadia ego*, in which Death declares that even paradise is his; Ryan poisons Arcadia's trees when Jack arrives.

The decisive name is Hephaestus, the geothermal district through which Jack reaches Ryan's office. Hephaestus, the Roman Vulcan, is the lame smith of the gods, cast down from Olympus; Milton calls him Mulciber and makes him the architect of Pandemonium, the capital of Hell, which rises in Book I of *Paradise Lost* "like an exhalation" with Doric pillars and a golden roof (I.710–730). The gold for that palace is dug by the crew of Mammon, "the least erected Spirit that fell," whose eyes, even in Heaven, were always lowered to admire the gold of its pavement (I.679–682). Milton's narrator comments: "Let none admire / That riches grow in Hell; that soil may best / Deserve the precious bane" (I.690–692). ADAM is the precious bane. Rapture is Pandemonium, a city built in the abyss by fallen genius on the strength of its own will, and Ryan's creed is Satan's before it is Rand's: "The mind is its own place" (I.254) and "Better to reign in Hell, than serve in Heav'n" (I.263). The Romantic reading of Milton's Satan as a heroic rebel, from Blake to Shelley, is one of the unacknowledged sources of Rand's Promethean heroes.

The architecture betrays its founder's philosophy in a further way. In *The Fountainhead*, Howard Roark, Rand's ideal architect, refuses every borrowed form, the Greek column, the Renaissance pediment, the decorative flourish copied from a past he did not make. His foil, Peter Keating, rises by copying exactly those forms, and Rand made Keating the type of what she called the second-hander, a man who lives through the borrowed judgements of others. The modernist creed behind Roark had its slogans: Louis Sullivan's principle that form ever follows function (Sullivan 1896) and Adolf Loos's polemic equating ornament with crime (Loos 1998). Rapture is Keating's city. Its Art Deco is draped in borrowed divinity: Greek gods in bronze, gilded reliefs, districts named for Olympus and Apollo, a lighthouse dominated by a colossal bust of the founder. Its skyline recalls the dramatic, shadowed towers of Hugh Ferriss's *The Metropolis of Tomorrow* (1929), the visionary drawings that taught a generation to see the skyscraper as a monument, and it answers to Rand's own reverence for the Manhattan skyline as the visible proof of human achievement. Under the sea that monument has no spectators but fish. Nor does Rapture's ornament follow function; it conceals it. The city's most important structures, the vents through which its girls move and the apparatus of extraction, are kept out of sight behind gilded surfaces. Loos's equation is inverted with a precision he could not have intended: in Rapture the ornament is not the crime, but it hides one. The prophet of the independent mind built a city of second-hand forms.

The city's kinship names are equally exact, and they belong to the 1950s. "Big Daddy" was the patriarch of Tennessee Williams's *Cat on a Hot Tin Roof* (1955), a dying planter whose estate his heirs circle amid what he calls the family's mendacity. *The Little*

Sister (1949) was Raymond Chandler's novel of a demure girl from Kansas whose innocence conceals a mercenary calculation. One model of Big Daddy, armed with a rivet gun, is named Rosie: the female war worker of 1943, Rosie the Riveter, returns as a hulking male body. The icon of women's industrial labour is reassigned to a man in the very decade in which the women of the war factories were sent home (Friedan 1963). Finally, Rapture names its most brutal relation of production in the language of family. Daddy, Sister, "Mr. Bubbles," and later "Mama" for Tenenbaum: the extraction of value from conscripted children is encoded in what Ferdinand Tönnies called the vocabulary of *Gemeinschaft*, the affective community, while it operates by the logic of *Gesellschaft*, the society of contract and exchange (Tönnies 1887).

II.5 Dialectic of Enlightenment Under the Sea

The master thesis of Horkheimer and Adorno's *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1947) is that myth is already enlightenment and that enlightenment reverts to mythology. Rapture enacts both halves. A city founded on reason names itself in myth, and its citizens revert to cult: Fontaine's contraband trade includes scripture, so that the god banished by the banner returns as a smuggled commodity, and the Little Sisters see the dead as angels.

The first excursus of the book reads Odysseus as the prototype of the bourgeois individual, who survives by cunning, self-denial and self-erasure. Its emblem is the name he gives Polyphemus: *Outis*, Nobody. Fontaine is Rapture's Odysseus. He survives by faking his death, assumes a new name, and speaks as nobody in particular, a disembodied voice on the radio. The book's reading of the Sirens is equally apt. Odysseus has himself bound to the mast so that he can hear the song without yielding to it, while his rowers, ears stopped with wax, row on: enjoyment of art for the master, deaf labour for the workers. Jack's condition is the Sirens episode inverted. He is bound not to resist a voice but to obey one, and the binding was performed by another hand. Jon Elster's analysis of precommitment as a "Ulysses contract" (Elster 1979) describes a rational self binding its future self; Jack's conditioning is a Ulysses contract signed on his behalf.

The second excursus argues that formal reason, once severed from substantive ends, cannot ground a prohibition against murder, and that Sade's libertines are therefore the honest heirs of Kant. Rapture's egoism produces its Sadeans, Sander Cohen and Frank Fontaine, as surely as it produces its entrepreneurs.

The city's economic language reverts to theology. Ryan describes the market as a "Great Chain" of industry, moved by an invisible hand. The phrase fuses two theological inheritances. The Great Chain of Being, whose history Arthur Lovejoy wrote, ordered every creature in a hierarchy descending from God; Pope's *Essay on Man* (1733–34) hymns it as a "Vast chain of being! which from God began" (Lovejoy 1936). Adam Smith's invisible hand, which leads the self-interested merchant "to promote an end which was no part of his intention" (Smith 1776, IV.ii.9), is, on Giorgio Agamben's

genealogy, the secularized form of the providential *oikonomia* by which God governs the world without appearing in it (Agamben 2011). Walter Benjamin had already called capitalism a religion, a cult without dogma, celebrated without pause, whose sacrament produces guilt and debt, the double sense of German *Schuld* (Benjamin [1921] 1996). The city that banished the gods worships a hidden one.

II.6 A Is Not A

Rand's metaphysics rests on the law of identity. Rapture's narrative is an anthology of its violations. Atlas is Fontaine. Atlas's wife and child, whose apparent murder by Ryan binds Jack to the cause, never existed. The photograph of Jack's parents is a fabrication, and his memories of a surface childhood are implants. The self-made man was made. The splicers' bodies will not hold a shape. The Little Sisters see corpses as angels. The climax of the plot is the revelation that A is not A.

Aristotle supplies the verdict that Rand, who acknowledged Aristotle as her only philosophical creditor, did not draw from him. Rand claimed the logician of identity. The political theorist of the *Politics* had written that the human being who cannot live in a political community, or who needs none because sufficient for himself, "must be either a beast or a god" (*Politics* I.2, 1253a, trans. Jowett). Rapture's citizens seceded from every polis and became exactly Aristotle's alternatives.

II.7 The Onomastic Confession

NAME	PRINCIPAL SOURCES	FUNCTION IN RAPTURE	WHAT THE NAME CONFESSES
Rapture	Darby; Nietzsche's *Rausch*; Cousteau; Bernini; Latin *raptus*, Livy	The city	Self-possession dissolved; the founding abduction
Atlas	Hesiod; Plato's *Critias*; Rand; Rockefeller Center	Fontaine's alias	The bearer of the world is someone else
ADAM and EVE	Genesis; Pico; Aristotle on form and matter	Genetic capital and consumable fuel	Masculine form produced from feminine matter
Gatherer's Garden	Eden	Plasmid vending machine	Paradise as a point of sale
Point Prometheus	Hesiod; Aeschylus; Shelley's *Modern Prometheus*	Research and conditioning facility	Theft of fire; making men from clay
Hephaestus	Homer; Milton's Mulciber	Power plant and seat of Ryan's rule	Rapture as Pandemonium
Apollo Square	Nietzsche's Apollonian	Poorhouses; insurgent base	Order and measure in the slum
Arcadia	Pastoral tradition; Poussin	Oxygen garden, poisoned	Death is present even in paradise

NAME	PRINCIPAL SOURCES	FUNCTION IN RAPTURE	WHAT THE NAME CONFESSES
Big Daddy	Williams, *Cat on a Hot Tin Roof*	Armoured guardian	The patriarch as conditioned property
Little Sister	Chandler, *The Little Sister*; sorority	ADAM gatherer	Kinship as the alibi of extraction
Rosie	Rosie the Riveter	Big Daddy model	Women's war labour reassigned to a male body

Read together, the names say what the founding speech forbids the city to say: that its sovereignty is borrowed, its reason intoxicated, its self-making manufactured, and its reproduction seized.

CHAPTER III

III

The Courteous Imperative

Consent, Contract, Conditioning

The conditioning formula is not a plot device but the grammatical kernel of liberal power. It commands in the form of a request, and so it condenses the thesis, developed by Carole Pateman, that consent is the modern form of subordination. This chapter analyses the formula philologically, pragmatically and politically, and then reads Ryan's death as the moment in which the doctrine of self-ownership meets its own grammar.

III.1 The Scene

Jack reaches Ryan's office through the geothermal plant of Hephaestus. Ryan, practising his putting, recounts the history Jack does not know: the embryo born of Ryan's liaison with the dancer Jasmine Jolene, purchased by Fontaine, accelerated in growth, conditioned by the scientist Yi Suchong and returned to the surface with a fabricated childhood. He demonstrates the conditioning with a sequence of trivial bodily commands, each prefixed by the formula, which Jack's body executes. Then he places the golf club in Jack's hands and orders, in the same courteous form, his own death, pronouncing as he dies that the man chooses while the slave obeys (*BioShock*, Rapture Central Control; cinematic). Moments later the radio voice drops its Irish warmth, names itself as Fontaine and attempts, through a further implanted command, to stop Jack's heart.

The scene is usually read as the hinge of a twist: the player discovers that every instruction followed was compelled. This chapter reads it as a lesson in grammar.

III.2 Will, You, Kin

The formula has three words, and each names something Jack has been denied. *Would* is the past and subjunctive of *will*, from Old English *willan*, the modal of volition; to ask "would you" is to address the hearer's will. *You* is the second person of direct address, the hail that singles out and constitutes its addressee. *Kindly* derives from *kind*, Old English (*ge*)*cynd*, whose senses include nature, birth, race and kin. The first words Shakespeare gives Hamlet pun on exactly this etymology, when the son describes himself in relation to the usurping uncle who has married his mother as "A little more than kin, and less than kind" (*Hamlet* 1.2.65). The formula appeals to a will that has been removed, addresses a self that was fabricated, and invokes a nature and a kinship that have been concealed. Its courtesy is an inventory of Jack's dispossessions.

The Hamlet resonance extends further. Hamlet is commanded by a ghost, a voice from beyond the visible, to kill the usurper who displaced his father. Jack is commanded by a voice from beyond the visible to kill his father on the usurper's behalf. *BioShock* is *Hamlet* with the ghost's allegiance reversed.

III.3 Speech Acts and the Abolition of the Hearer

J. L. Austin distinguished the locutionary act of saying something meaningful, the illocutionary act performed in saying it (promising, requesting, commanding), and the perlocutionary act of producing effects by saying it (persuading, alarming, getting someone to act) (Austin 1962). John Searle showed that sentences such as "would you...?" are, literally, questions about the hearer's willingness, and conventionally serve as requests; their politeness derives from the fact that they presuppose, and leave open, the hearer's option to refuse (Searle 1975). Penelope Brown and Stephen Levinson classified conventional indirectness as a strategy of negative politeness: redress offered to the hearer's "negative face," the desire to be unimpeded in action (Brown and Levinson 1987). Grammatically, then, "would you kindly" is the most respectful available acknowledgement of another's freedom. It asks; it does not tell; and it adds an adverb of grace.

In ordinary use the perlocutionary effect of a request is contingent. Whether the hearer complies depends on the hearer, and that dependence is what distinguishes a request from a command and a person from a mechanism. In Jack's case the perlocution is guaranteed. The illocutionary form of a request is fused to the perlocutionary certainty of a reflex. A speech act whose effect is guaranteed has abolished the hearer as a party to the act. Its addressee remains grammatically present and pragmatically absent.

This thesis names the resulting form *the courteous imperative*: a command that wears the grammar of a request, in which consent is not overridden but simulated, and in which the acknowledgement of the other's freedom becomes the vehicle of its abolition.

III.4 Kant's Two Imperatives and a Third

Kant distinguished the categorical imperative, which commands unconditionally because it issues from reason's own legislation, from hypothetical imperatives, which command only on condition that the agent wills some end (Kant 1785). The first expresses autonomy, the will giving itself the law; the second expresses heteronomy, the will moved by an object of desire. Kant's Formula of Humanity requires that humanity, in oneself and in others, be treated always also as an end and never merely as a means.

IMPERATIVE	GRAMMATICAL FORM	SOURCE OF ITS FORCE	RELATION TO THE WILL	EXEMPLAR
Categorical	Unconditional command	Reason's self-legislation	Autonomy: the will gives itself the law	Kant's moral law
Hypothetical	Conditional: if you want X, do Y	Desire for an end	Heteronomy: the will is moved by an object	Kant's prudent merchant
Courteous	Request: would you...?	Implanted conditioning	Simulated autonomy: the will is addressed in order to be bypassed	Fontaine's formula

The courteous imperative is the Formula of Humanity's grammatical shell with heteronomy inside it. It treats its addressee, in form, as an end whose consent is sought, and, in substance, as a means whose compliance is assured. It is therefore more insidious than a command, which at least announces the relation of force it institutes.

III.5 Contract as the Form of Subordination

Pateman's argument in *The Sexual Contract* is that contract, far from being the antithesis of subordination, is the specifically modern means of creating it. The employment contract, the marriage contract and, in the limit, the surrogacy contract and the voluntary slave contract all take the form of free agreements between owners of "property in the person," and each institutes a relation of command and obedience that the form conceals (Pateman 1988). The courteous imperative is contract reduced to a single sentence. It performs the formal acknowledgement of the other's freedom, the question "would you?", that secures the other's subjection, and it does so in the idiom of politeness that liberal market societies use to make command palatable: the "please" of service, the "I agree" of the terms of use, the consent form that cannot be declined if one wishes to proceed.

Locke had placed a limit on this logic. Because human beings are God's "workmanship" and therefore his property (Second Treatise §6), no one has an arbitrary power over his own life, and no one can "by compact or his own consent, enslave himself to any one" (§23). The theological premise of Lockean self-ownership is a prior ownership by God, and it is that prior ownership which forbids self-enslavement and suicide. Ryan's banner removes the premise. Without God, self-ownership becomes absolute, and absolute ownership includes *abusus*. Ryan's death completes the arc that began with the burned forest. He commands his own destruction in the courteous form, and so exercises upon himself the right that Locke denied to any creature. At the same moment, Jack embodies the other right Locke denied: he is the self-enslavement that consent could never produce, manufactured instead by purchase and conditioning.

III.6 Interpellation and Excitable Speech

Louis Althusser described ideology as the mechanism that "interpellates" individuals as subjects. A policeman calls out "Hey, you there!"; the individual turns, recognizing himself as the one addressed, and in that turn becomes a subject, which is to say subjected. The success of ideology lies in the fact that subjects then "work by themselves," freely accepting their subjection as the expression of their own will (Althusser 1971). The formula is interpellation made literal and mechanical, and it explains why Jack, and the player through him, experiences compulsion as choice. The subjective form of subjection is the feeling of having chosen.

Judith Butler, joining Austin to Althusser, argued that the performative force of an utterance derives from its citation of prior utterances, and that the gap between an utterance and its effects is the site of possible resistance and resignification (Butler 1997). Jack's conditioning is a citation that compels. Its undoing, which Tenenbaum achieves through an antidote and a sustained practice of care, opens exactly the gap Butler theorizes. After it, the formula can be heard as a phrase and not as a reflex.

The player is interpellated twice. Within the fiction, by the formula; within the form, by the objectives, waypoints and instructions that structure any linear game. The twist works because it reveals the second interpellation through the first. Every objective was a hail, and every turn toward it was an act of recognition.

The game's first words make the same point about character. Jack's opening narration recalls parents who told him he was special, born to do great things. This is the founding affect of Randian individualism, the conviction of one's own exceptional destiny that animates Roark and Galt, and the game later reveals the parents, the childhood and the memory to be fabrications. The belief in one's own exceptionality, which the ideology of the self-made man treats as the inner source of achievement, is in Jack's case an implant: the first hail he ever answered was a lie about his own uniqueness. Althusser's subject who works by himself has rarely been given so exact an

image. The self-made man's sense of being chosen was installed by the people who made him.

III.7 Brainwashing, 1950–1962

The formula belongs to a precise Cold War archive. The journalist Edward Hunter popularized the word "brain-washing" in 1950 and published *Brain-Washing in Red China* in 1951. William Sargant's *Battle for the Mind* (1957) explained religious and political conversion through Pavlovian conditioning. Robert Jay Lifton's *Thought Reform and the Psychology of Totalism* (1961) anatomized the techniques by which identity could be dismantled and rebuilt. The CIA's MKUltra programme began in 1953. Among the research it funded was the work of D. Ewen Cameron at the Allan Memorial Institute in Montreal, who in 1956 described a technique he called "psychic driving": the repeated playback of recorded verbal messages to patients, for many hours a day, in order to implant new patterns of behaviour (Cameron 1956).

Naomi Klein's *The Shock Doctrine*, published within weeks of *BioShock*'s release in August 2007, opens with Cameron's experiments and argues that psychiatric depatterning and the economic "shock therapy" associated with Milton Friedman share a single logic: wipe the slate in crisis, then write on it (Klein 2007). The game's title derives from its studio lineage in *System Shock* and owes nothing to Klein, which makes the convergence more striking. Rapture is a city of recorded voices; Jack is psychically driven by a radio; and the first plasmid he receives, in the opening minutes, is Electro Bolt, the power to deliver an electric shock.

Richard Condon's *The Manchurian Candidate* (1959), filmed in 1962, gave the period its archetypal sleeper agent: a decorated veteran conditioned in captivity to kill on the presentation of a playing card. His handler is his own mother. Condon's novel draws on Philip Wylie's diatribe against "momism" in *Generation of Vipers* (1942), which blamed smothering American mothers for the nation's weakness. *BioShock* inverts the trope with precision. The handler is a counterfeit father, and the mother is the one who deprograms. Chapter V returns to this inversion.

III.8 Skinner Against Rand

B. F. Skinner's *Walden Two* (1948) imagined a utopian community engineered through the systematic arrangement of reinforcements, and his *Beyond Freedom and Dignity* (1971) argued that the "autonomous man" of liberal tradition is a pre-scientific fiction, an obstacle to the rational design of culture. Rand answered in "The Stimulus and the Response" (1972), a polemic charging that Skinner's science rested on the denial of volitional consciousness and therefore of the human (Rand 1982). The Rand–Skinner quarrel is the philosophical fault line that *BioShock* dramatizes. Ryan is the party of volition; Suchong and Fontaine are the party of conditioning. The plot sides with

Skinner, since Jack was conditioned. The rhetoric sides with Rand, since Ryan dies proclaiming the dignity of choice. The resolution sides with neither: Jack is freed not by the reassertion of his will but by another person's care, and the decisive act of the ending belongs to a collective that neither Rand nor Skinner can theorize.

III.9 Watchword and Password: Nudge and Control

Gilles Deleuze distinguished disciplinary societies, organized by watchwords (*mots d'ordre*), from societies of control, organized by passwords (*mots de passe*) that grant or deny access (Deleuze 1992). Ryan governs by watchword: banners, slogans, public-address homilies, advertisements for the Great Chain. Fontaine governs by password. His formula persuades no one of anything; it unlocks a body, as Ryan's genetic locks unlock bathyspheres and doors to the right sequence of DNA. The passage from Ryan to Fontaine is the passage from discipline to control.

Richard Thaler and Cass Sunstein later named the governing style of control societies *libertarian paternalism*: the design of "choice architecture" that steers people toward chosen outcomes while preserving the formal freedom to choose otherwise (Thaler and Sunstein 2003; 2008). The oxymoron names Rapture's political arc, from libertarian founding to paternal control, and the formula's mechanism, which preserves the form of choice while foreclosing its substance. The objective marker on a game's map is a modest instance of the same architecture.

III.10 The Acousmatic Sovereign

Michel Chion's term *acousmêtre* designates a voice heard without its source being seen. Such a voice acquires, in film, quasi-divine powers of ubiquity, omniscience and omnipotence, and it loses them at the moment of "de-acousmatization," when it is attached to a visible, finite body; the Wizard of Oz behind his curtain is the paradigm (Chion 1999). Rapture is an acousmatic city. Ryan rules it as a public-address voice; Atlas guides Jack as a radio voice; the dead speak through audio diaries. Atlas is a perfect acousmêtre, and his de-acousmatization proceeds in two stages, first when the voice is unmasked as Fontaine's and then when Fontaine appears in the flesh as a grotesque, mortal giant. Ryan is acousmatic until Jack enters his office. Both lose their power when they acquire bodies. Mladen Dolar's account of the voice as the object of command, the voice of the law that addresses the subject before it means anything, explains why the formula works through sound (Dolar 2006).

The audio diaries are prosopopoeia, the rhetorical figure that, in Paul de Man's analysis, gives face and voice to the absent and the dead (de Man 1979). The player is cast as the auditor of the dead, which Chapter IV connects to Benjamin's angel of history.

Kaja Silverman showed that classical cinema withholds disembodied vocal authority from women. The authoritative voice-over is male, while the female voice is anchored to a visible body and contained within the diegesis (Silverman 1988). *BioShock*'s second act reverses the convention. After Ryan's death the guiding acousmatic voice passes from Atlas to Brigid Tenenbaum, who directs Jack by radio for the remainder of the game. The maternal voice acquires the disembodied authority cinema reserved for fathers.

III.11 Master, Slave, Father, Son

In Hegel's dialectic of lordship and bondage, self-consciousness requires recognition by another self-consciousness. In the struggle that follows, the one who risks his life becomes master and the one who clings to life becomes bondsman. The reversal follows: the master's recognition is hollow, because it comes from one he does not recognize as an equal, while the bondsman, disciplined by the fear of death and by formative labour on the world, achieves an independent consciousness (Hegel 1807, §§178–196; Kojève 1969). Ryan's death stages the struggle with uncanny fidelity. He gives his life to prove that he is the one who chooses, and he makes Jack the instrument of that death to prove that Jack is the one who obeys. The recognition he seeks is from his son, and it is not given; he dies recognized by no one. Jack, the bondsman, then undergoes exactly the education Hegel prescribes. He is confronted with death when Fontaine's command begins to stop his heart, and he labours, assembling the suit and the voice of a Big Daddy, until he can confront his false master.

The game's Vita-Chambers, which reconstitute Jack after every death, complicate the dialectic. The one who cannot die cannot risk his life, and in Hegel's terms cannot become master. The player's immortality is the bondsman's condition in mechanical form.

The Oedipal structure is equally exact. Oedipus kills his father at the crossroads without knowing who he is; Jack kills his father knowing who he is, and without being free not to. The oracle is a radio. In Freud's *Totem and Taboo* (1913), the brothers of the primal horde kill the father and then institute the law, out of guilt, in his name. In Rapture, after the patricide, the law that ends the old order is not instituted by brothers. Chapter VIII shows who institutes it.

Ryan's death is, finally, the purest act of Bataillean sovereignty in the game: an expenditure without utility, a refusal of the servile calculus of ends (Bataille 1988). And it is immediately reabsorbed into utility. The genetic key that dies with Ryan lives on in his son, and Fontaine uses that son to seize the city's controls. The sovereign moment is a business transaction, and the golf club, the leisure instrument of the executive class, is its pen.

III.12 Conclusion: The Grammar of Liberal Power

The twist of *BioShock* is commonly summarized as the discovery that Jack was never free. The deeper discovery is that his unfreedom spoke the language of courtesy. The courteous imperative is the form in which liberal societies command: through requests that cannot be refused, consents that cannot be withheld, nudges that preserve the appearance of choice. Ryan, who believed that contract was the opposite of force, is killed by a contract's grammar.

CHAPTER IV

IV

The Parasite and the Host

ADAM and the Necro-Maternal Economy

Rapture is not a free market that failed. It is a parasitic order that worked, for as long as its hosts could be held in place. Its founding relation is not exchange but one-way extraction, and the extraction runs through the bodies of girls who recycle the dead into value. This chapter descends from Rapture's rhetoric of trade to its regime of production, and from there to the reproductive labour beneath it.

IV.1 The Slug

ADAM begins with a discovery recorded in Brigid Tenenbaum's diaries. A species of sea slug native to the waters around Rapture produces a substance capable of rewriting genetic material; in the game's account, a form of unstable stem cell. Yields from the slug alone are meagre. Implanted in the stomach of a human host, and most effectively in a young girl, it produces ADAM in commercial quantities. Fontaine finances the research and brings the product to market; Ryan, after Fontaine's apparent death, nationalizes it. Every plasmid, every gene tonic and every splicer's power in Rapture therefore originates in a parasite housed in a child.

The irony is structural, not decorative. "Parasite" is Ryan's favourite epithet, Rand's name for the looters and moochers who consume what producers create. The biological parasite at the base of Rapture's value chain is the literal form of what Ryan projects onto his enemies. The producer's paradise runs on a parasite, and the parasite runs on a girl.

IV.2 Serres: The Parasite as the First Relation

Michel Serres argued that parasitism, not exchange, is the elementary relation of all systems. The parasite takes without giving back; its relation to its host is irreversible; and the French word names three things at once, the biological parasite, the social parasite who eats at another's table, and the static or noise that interrupts a channel of communication (Serres 1982). Exchange, on this account, is a late and fragile stabilization of cascades of parasitism, in which each party eats at the table of the one before. Value-for-value is the exception; abuse comes first.

Rapture is a Serresian cascade. The slug feeds on the girl. The girl feeds on the dead, drawing ADAM from corpses with a needle. The splicer feeds on the girl, and the Big Daddy is welded to her service. Fontaine feeds on Ryan's market, Atlas on Jack's conditioning, and the voice of Atlas is, in the third sense, the noise in the channel: a transmission that parasitizes the city's radio to command its listener. The player, harvesting or rescuing, feeds on everything. Rand's trader principle, the exchange of value for value by mutual consent, is the official language of the city and the alibi of its actual economy. This is what the thesis calls *parasitic sovereignty*: the sovereign self is the last parasite in the cascade, the one who has taken so much from so many that he can call himself a producer.

IV.3 The Necro-Maternal Economy

The Little Sisters are girls implanted with the slug and conditioned to perform a single circuit of labour. Escorted by a Big Daddy, they find a corpse, extract its residual ADAM with an oversized syringe, ingest it, process it in their bodies, and return through the walls of the city by narrow vents. Conditioning shields them from the horror of the work: they call the corpses "angels," sing to them, and, as *BioShock 2* would later render visually, perceive Rapture's ruins as a world of clean surfaces and petals. Their labour is unwaged, conscripted and infantilized, and it is named in the language of family.

The figure is a reproductive apparatus in every sense the word allows. The girls host an organism in the belly, in a figuration of pregnancy. They gestate and process a substance that sustains others. They return value to a system that does not count their work as work. Silvia Federici's *Caliban and the Witch* argued that the transition to capitalism required, alongside the enclosure of the commons, the enclosure of women's bodies, whose reproductive capacity was disciplined and converted into a resource for capital and state; for women, Federici writes, the body became what the factory was for the male wage worker, the primary site of exploitation and of resistance (Federici 2004). Her earlier pamphlet *Wages Against Housework* argued that the domestic labour that reproduces labour-power is extracted precisely by being called love rather than work

(Federici 1975), extending the analysis Mariarosa Dalla Costa and Selma James had made of the home as a hidden site of production (Dalla Costa and James 1972). Rapture's economy is built on the same misrecognition. What the girls do is called sisterhood and daughterhood. It is the production of capital.

Nancy Fraser has generalized the point. Capitalist production depends on background conditions that it does not produce and does not pay for: social reproduction, the natural world and public power. Capital consumes these conditions as if they were free and inexhaustible, and so undermines the ground it stands on, a tendency Fraser names "cannibal capitalism" (Fraser 2016; 2022). Rapture devours all three. It consumes social reproduction in the Little Sisters, nature in the slug and the sea and the poisoned trees of Arcadia, and public power in Ryan's privatized sovereignty.

Marx supplies the image that makes the Little Sisters legible as political economy. In the Moore–Aveling translation of *Capital*, "Capital is dead labour, that, vampire-like, only lives by sucking living labour, and lives the more, the more labour it sucks" (Marx [1867] 1887, ch. 10). Rapture inverts and doubles the figure. The girls draw ADAM from the dead, from the bodies in which the city's spent labour lies, while the city draws its life from the living labour of the girls. Mark Neocleous has shown how thoroughly Marx's economics is a political economy of the dead (Neocleous 2003). *BioShock* gives that political economy a syringe.

The angels deserve a further word. In the ninth of his theses "On the Concept of History" (1940), Walter Benjamin describes the angel of history, its face turned toward the past, seeing a single catastrophe that keeps piling wreckage at its feet, unable to stay and make whole what has been smashed because a storm called progress drives it forward. In the sixth thesis he warns that even the dead will not be safe from the enemy if he wins. In Rapture the warning is literal: the dead are not safe, because they are mined. The Little Sisters call the dead angels and draw their remaining value. They are Benjamin's angel inverted, the wreckage of progress turned into its raw material and harvested by children.

Marx described the commodity as an object "abounding in metaphysical subtleties and theological niceties" in which a social relation between people appears as a relation between things and a property of the thing itself (Marx [1867] 1887, ch. 1, §4). The plasmid is commodity fetishism made literal. It confers what looks like magic, fire from the fingertips, lightning, motion at a distance, and conceals in that magic the labour of the girls who produced it. The power appears to belong to the product; it belongs to its producers.

The girls' perception of corpses as angels is a conditioned reversal of abjection. Julia Kristeva identified the corpse as the most extreme form of the abject, the thing the subject must continually expel in order to go on living as a subject (Kristeva 1982). The Little Sisters are made to embrace what every subject must thrust away, and their conditioning converts abjection into adoration because no free subject would perform

this labour. Barbara Creed's analysis of the "monstrous-feminine" in horror cinema shows how often the genre locates horror in the female and the maternal (Creed 1993). *BioShock* displaces it. The Little Sisters are uncanny, but the horror is what has been done to them, not what they are. Aldous Huxley's conditioned castes, made to love their servitude, and Sara Ahmed's account of happiness as an orientation that directs subjects toward approved objects (Huxley 1932; Ahmed 2010) describe the same technology: contentment installed so that exploitation will be experienced as joy.

The thesis therefore names Rapture's economy *necro-maternal*: value produced by conscripted girls who recycle the dead through their bodies, under the sign of family, for the benefit of men who call themselves self-made.

IV.4 The Traffic in Girls

Claude Lévi-Strauss argued in 1949 that kinship, and with it culture, rests on exogamy and the exchange of women among groups of men. Gayle Rubin turned the argument into a critique. In "The Traffic in Women" (1975) she showed that the exchange of women is the foundation of a "sex/gender system" in which women are conduits of relationships among men rather than partners to them. Luce Irigaray's "Women on the Market" read Marx's analysis of the commodity through the same lens: women circulate among men as goods with a use value, reproduction, and an exchange value, the alliances they secure, while the social order is built among the men who exchange them (Irigaray 1985a).

The Little Sisters are passed among men in exactly this way: from Fontaine, who gathers them, to Ryan, who nationalizes them, to the splicers who hunt them, to Jack, who decides whether to harvest or to rescue. They move through the city's walls by vents built for them. They are trafficked in both senses: taken from families and orphanages, and moved through a network. Ursula K. Le Guin called the ideology of her capitalist planet Urras *propertarian*, and made the subordination of women, ornamental and excluded from science, one of its central features (Le Guin 1974). Rapture is the most propertarian city in fiction, and its women are dancers, socialites, surgical patients and a single scientist, while its girls are capital.

IV.5 Human Capital: Foucault's Neoliberal Subject

In his lectures of 1978–79, Michel Foucault analysed American neoliberalism, above all the Chicago School of Theodore Schultz and Gary Becker, as a redefinition of the individual. The worker becomes an entrepreneur of himself, a manager of his own human capital, and every activity, from education to marriage, becomes an investment. Foucault observed that genetics might extend this logic to the body's inheritance, making one's hereditary endowment a form of capital to be improved and protected, and raising the prospect of a market in good genes (Foucault 2008). Rapture is that

market realized. Each citizen becomes an entrepreneur of his genome; the gene tonics that improve combat, engineering or physical capacities are investments in human capital in the most literal sense. Homo economicus becomes homo geneticus, and Becker's economic theory of the family, which treats children as durable goods (Becker 1981), is surpassed. In Rapture, children are productive capital.

The demand for that capital is manufactured. John Kenneth Galbraith's *The Affluent Society* (1958) described a "dependence effect" in which production creates the wants it then satisfies. ADAM addiction is the dependence effect as physiology: each dose creates the need for the next. Vance Packard's *The Hidden Persuaders* (1957) exposed the motivational researchers who taught advertising to reach beneath conscious choice. Rapture's plasmid commercials and jingles, and its use of a child's voice and image to sell the products of children's labour, belong to Packard's world.

Bataille's general economy completes the analysis. A system that produces more energy than it needs for its own reproduction must spend the surplus, and if it cannot spend it gloriously it will spend it catastrophically, in war (Bataille 1988). Rapture's surplus is ADAM, and the civil war that begins on New Year's Eve 1958 is its expenditure.

IV.6 Necropolitics, Bare Life, and Omelas

Achille Mbembe defined necropolitics as the sovereign power to decide who may live and who must die, and described the zones in which populations are reduced to the condition of the living dead (Mbembe 2003). Rapture after 1958 is such a zone, and the harvest decision delegates necropolitical sovereignty to the player. Giorgio Agamben's *homo sacer* is the figure who may be killed without the killing counting as homicide, a life included in the political order only through its exclusion from it, and the camp is the space that opens when the exception becomes the rule (Agamben 1998). In Rapture, harvesting a Little Sister is not murder. It is extraction. The girl is bare life in Agamben's precise sense, and Rapture, in its final phase, is a camp. Tenenbaum, who survived the Nazi camps, recognizes what she has helped build; Chapter V follows her.

The structure of the city has a canonical philosophical parable. In 1891 William James imagined a world in which millions are kept permanently happy on the single condition that "a certain lost soul on the far-off edge of things should lead a life of lonely torture," and argued that our moral intuition rejects the bargain (James 1891). Dostoevsky's Ivan Karamazov refuses to accept any universal harmony bought with the tears of one tortured child (Dostoevsky 1880, Book V). Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), which credits James, imagines a city whose happiness depends on a single child kept in misery in a basement; most citizens accept the bargain, and a few walk away. Rapture is Omelas with its basement child multiplied and moved into the walls. Its citizens do not merely tolerate the child's suffering; they consume its products by the dose. Whether the player can walk away is the question of Chapter VII.

IV.7 Conclusion: The Parasitic Order

Rapture's economy did not fail because the market was left free. It succeeded as a parasitic order and collapsed when its hosts were removed, rescued, killed or turned. The producer is the host's parasite, and Ryan's favourite word names, in the end, himself.

CHAPTER V

V

Fathers, Daughters, Protectors

Feminist Readings of Rapture

BioShock's feminism lies not in its moral choice, which is paternal on both branches, but in its structure. Its economy rests on girls; its mother deprograms; its women scientists are its conscience; its protector-men are property; and its daughters act last. This chapter reads Rapture's gender order through the canon of feminist theory and fiction, and marks where the game's own frame falls short of what its structure discloses.

V.1 A Choice Between Two Voices

Jack's first encounter with a Little Sister stages the moral choice as a contest of voices. Atlas, on the radio, urges him to harvest the girl, insisting that whatever she once was, she is no longer a child. Tenenbaum appears in person, armed, and pleads for her. The dilemma is presented as a struggle between a paternal and a maternal voice for the hands of a son. The camera is Jack's, and the image at the moment of decision is of a man's hand reaching toward a girl who cannot escape it. Laura Mulvey's analysis of the cinematic gaze, structured by a male look that possesses and a female image that is looked at (Mulvey 1975), finds in the first-person viewpoint its purest apparatus.

Joanna Russ observed that the plots available in Western narrative are overwhelmingly plots for male protagonists, in which women appear as objects, obstacles or prizes (Russ 1972). The Little Sister has no plot. Her fate is an option in Jack's. Harvest kills her; rescue removes the slug and returns her to girlhood. Both are decisions made about her by a man who holds her. Rescue is not liberation. It is adoption.

V.2 Big Daddies and the Logic of Masculinist Protection

The Big Daddies are men, drawn, the game's record suggests, from prisoners and the destitute, surgically and genetically altered, sealed in armoured diving suits and bonded to a single Little Sister by conditioning. They protect her with lethal violence. They do not speak; they moan like whales. They cannot leave her.

Iris Marion Young described the "logic of masculinist protection," in which the good man shields his dependants from external threat and receives, in exchange, their obedience; she argued that the post-2001 security state adopted the same logic toward its citizens, subordinating those it claimed to protect (Young 2003). The Big Daddy literalizes masculinist protection and turns it inside out. The protector is himself property, conditioned and voiceless, and his protection is also custody. He guards the girl from those who would harvest her and guards the city's supply from the girl's escape. bell hooks argued that patriarchy demands of boys and men a kind of psychic self-mutilation, the killing-off of whatever parts of the self do not serve dominance (hooks 2004). The Big Daddy is that mutilation made flesh. R. W. Connell's distinction between hegemonic and subordinated masculinities completes the picture (Connell 1995). The Big Daddy looks like the apex of masculinity, vast and armoured. He is in fact its most subordinated form, a labourer whose masculinity is a uniform.

The plot of the second act makes Jack a Big Daddy. To reach Fontaine he must assemble a suit, a voice and the chemical signature that will persuade the Little Sisters to accept him, and the final district is an escort mission in which he protects them as they open the way. The male hero's emancipation from his false father requires him to assume the paternal armour. In Young's terms, the condition of masculine freedom is the protector role. The game half-knows this. The armour that frees Jack is the armour that enslaved every man who wore it before him.

V.3 Brigid Tenenbaum: The Grey Zone and the Ethics of Care

Tenenbaum's diaries give her history in fragments. A German-Jewish geneticist, she survived the Nazi camps by assisting the camp doctors in their experiments, valued for a talent she exercised, by her own account, without moral feeling. In Rapture she identified the slug's properties, devised the implantation and conditioning of the girls and treated them as material. Then something changed. She records an attachment she had not expected to feel, defects, shelters the girls, develops the means to remove the slug and restore them, and becomes Jack's guide (*BioShock*, various districts; audio diaries).

Primo Levi's late essay on the "grey zone" described the camp's moral gradient, in which privileged prisoners and members of the Sonderkommando were drawn by coercion into complicity, and warned against the easy judgement of those who were not

there (Levi 1988). Tenenbaum stands in the grey zone twice: as a prisoner who collaborated to survive, and as a free woman who rebuilt, in Rapture, a regime of experimentation on the defenceless. Levi's Italian title, *I sommersi e i salvati*, the drowned and the saved, is uncannily apt for a city at the bottom of the sea, and the game's binary of harvest and rescue is a choice between the drowned and the saved. That the game places a camp survivor at its moral centre insists that the player feel what the decision to sort lives resembles, without permitting the analogy to become equivalence.

Levi's grey zone explains the camp; Hannah Arendt's report on Adolf Eichmann helps explain Rapture. Arendt located the most consequential evil not in demonic hatred but in thoughtlessness: a functionary's incapacity to think from the standpoint of anyone else, sheltered by cliché and procedure (Arendt 1963). The distinction matters for Tenenbaum. In the camp she acted under coercion. In Rapture she was free, and her own account of her early work there, talent exercised without moral feeling and children treated as material, fits Arendt's portrait more closely than any demonology. Her conversion is then the recovery of the faculty whose absence Arendt diagnosed, the capacity, which Arendt later developed from Kant's notion of an enlarged mentality, to think from the place of another (Arendt 1982). Tenenbaum begins to think when she begins to see the girls.

Tenenbaum's discovery is also a story of appropriated female science. Margaret Rossiter named the "Matilda effect," the systematic under-recognition of women's contributions to science (Rossiter 1993); its emblem is Rosalind Franklin, whose X-ray diffraction data were used without her knowledge in the 1953 model of the double helix (Maddox 2002). Tenenbaum's discovery is commercialized by Fontaine and expropriated by Ryan. Evelyn Fox Keller's biography of the geneticist Barbara McClintock described a science conducted through attentive intimacy, a "feeling for the organism," rather than through domination, and Keller's later work criticized the discourse of the gene as a master molecule issuing commands (Keller 1983; 1985; 2000). Tenenbaum's conversion is a passage from a dominating to a relational epistemology. That Ryan's devoted lover in the audio diaries bears the surname McClintock is at least an onomastic resonance.

The ethics Tenenbaum adopts is an ethics of care. Carol Gilligan identified a moral voice organized around relationships and responsibilities rather than rights and rules (Gilligan 1982). Nel Noddings described care as engrossment in another and the displacement of one's own motives by theirs (Noddings 1984). Virginia Held developed care into a political ethics capable of criticizing the market's reach into every domain of life (Held 2006). Rapture is a city of rights without care. Tenenbaum introduces care, and the game's second act is narrated in her voice.

A feminist reading must register a risk. The plot of the cold woman scientist redeemed by the discovery of her maternal feeling can reinscribe an essentialist myth of maternal instinct. Sara Ruddick's *Maternal Thinking* supplies the corrective, and the

game supplies the evidence for it. Ruddick defined mothering as a practice, a discipline of thought and action organized around the preservation, growth and social acceptability of a child, available to anyone who does the work and not given by nature (Ruddick 1989). Tenenbaum says that the feeling was not there and then came, and what she does about it is labour: research, shelter, defence, instruction. Her motherhood is achieved, not innate. The game thereby inverts the Cold War mythology that Chapter III traced to *The Manchurian Candidate*, in which the mother is the handler. Here the counterfeit father programmes and the mother undoes the programming.

V.4 Steinman and the Surgical Pygmalion

The first great district Jack explores is the Medical Pavilion, the domain of the plastic surgeon J. S. Steinman. His diaries trace a descent from cosmetic practice into an ADAM-fuelled obsession with an ideal of beauty, a voice he identifies as Aphrodite's, and a contempt for the symmetry his patients request; his clinic is strewn with the women he has carved (*BioShock*, Medical Pavilion; audio diaries). In Ovid, Pygmalion, disgusted by real women, carves an ideal one and prays her into life (*Metamorphoses* X). Steinman reverses him. He carves living women toward an ideal and kills them.

Kathryn Pauly Morgan's "Women and the Knife" analysed cosmetic surgery as a colonization of women's bodies by male aesthetic norms, in which ordinary features are reclassified as defects requiring correction (Morgan 1991). Susan Bordo read the disciplined female body as a text of cultural power (Bordo 1993), and Naomi Wolf described beauty as a currency within a political economy that keeps women occupied and anxious (Wolf 1990). Kathy Davis's ethnography of women who chose surgery warns against treating them as dupes, a caution any reading of Steinman's victims should respect (Davis 1995). Rapture fuses the beauty economy with genetic power. That the game's exploration of the city begins under the male surgeon's knife is a structural statement: the first thing Rapture shows of its sciences is a man's hand on women's faces.

V.5 Rapture's Women

Jasmine Jolene, a dancer and Ryan's mistress, conceived the child who became Jack, and the embryo was sold to Fontaine. Her story is the surrogacy contract in its starkest form: a woman's reproductive capacity alienated as property in a transaction among men (Pateman 1988). Shulamith Firestone had argued that the biological family and the burden of pregnancy are the material root of women's subordination, and that technologies of artificial reproduction could free women from it, but only after a feminist revolution had seized control of those technologies; without one, they would be turned against women (Firestone 1970). Rapture confirms the caveat. Accelerated

gestation and implanted production do not free anyone in a propertarian city. They extract.

The surface supplies the counter-image. In May 1960, the year Jack descends, the United States Food and Drug Administration approved Enovid as the first oral contraceptive, the technology that more than any other placed control of fertility in women's own hands. As Rapture's reproductive regime collapsed below, a technology realizing part of Firestone's hope was arriving above. Its history confirms her caveat rather than refuting it. The pill's development was financed by Katharine McCormick and championed by Margaret Sanger, a pioneer of birth control who also lent her voice to eugenic arguments, and its large-scale trials were conducted among women in Puerto Rico who were told little about the risks (May 2010). The decisive question, on the surface as under the sea, is who controls the technology of reproduction, and in whose interest.

Julie Langford, the botanist who designed Arcadia, helps Jack devise the Lazarus Vector to revive the trees that Ryan has poisoned, and Ryan kills her for it (*BioShock*, Arcadia). She is Rachel Carson in Rapture. Carson's *The Sea Around Us* (1951) and *Silent Spring* (1962) practised a science of attention and wonder and indicted the "control of nature" as an arrogance; Stacy Alaimo's feminist account of trans-corporeality, the porousness of bodies and environments, extends Carson's insight to the splicer's body, permeated by a sea creature's chemistry (Alaimo 2010). The woman scientist who restores life is murdered by the man who poisons the garden.

Diane McClintock, a socialite, records in her diaries a passage from devotion to Ryan, through injury in the New Year's Eve attack, to sympathy with the insurgency. Her arc is a story of a woman defined by her relation to a powerful man, the condition Betty Friedan would call the feminine mystique (Friedan 1963), discovering that she was never part of the city's elect. And one of the game's most disquieting tableaux is a female splicer crooning a lullaby over a perambulator in which lies a revolver: maternal practice displaced onto a weapon, the commodity as child.

V.6 Beauvoir: Immanence, Transcendence, and the Ethics of Ambiguity

Simone de Beauvoir's *The Second Sex* (1949) described woman as constituted as the Other and confined to immanence, the repetitive maintenance and reproduction of life, while man claims transcendence, the project that surpasses the given toward a future. Rapture's division of labour reproduces the opposition exactly. Ryan's city is a project, a monument to transcendence. The Little Sisters perform a loop: the same circuit, the same act, the same return, over and over, which the game's mechanics render with uncanny literalness as a fixed patrol route between vents and corpses.

Beauvoir's earlier *The Ethics of Ambiguity* (1947) argued that freedom is always situated and embodied, and that one cannot will oneself free without willing others free; oppression is the condition of those whose transcendence is condemned to fall

back into immanence. The book offers a typology of failed relations to freedom, and it fits Rapture's cast with startling precision.

FIGURE	BEAUVOIR'S TYPE	MODE OF UNFREEDOM	OUTCOME
Andrew Ryan	The serious man	Subordinates freedom to an idol, the market and the city, and sacrifices persons to it	Tyranny, then a staged death
Frank Fontaine	The adventurer	Uses others as instruments of his own freedom, indifferent to every end but his own	Killed by the girls
Sander Cohen	The passionate man	Fixed on his work to the exclusion of others' freedom; murders for the art	Madness and isolation
Yi Suchong	The serious man as technician	Treats the experiment as absolute and persons as material	Killed by the bond he engineered
The splicers	What Beauvoir calls the sub-man	Flees freedom into mere appetite; available to any demagogue	Mobilized by Atlas, then consumed
Jack	The child	Lives inside a world of given commands whose authority he cannot question	Freed into the anguish of choice
Brigid Tenenbaum	The nihilist who becomes free	Passes from indifference to willing the freedom of others	Guide, rescuer, narrator
The Little Sisters	The oppressed kept in childhood	Their transcendence is foreclosed and their world prepared for them	Their first collective act is their own

Beauvoir's warning that the adventurer readily becomes a tyrant describes Fontaine's trajectory, and her account of Suchong's type explains why the scientist who engineered the bond between Big Daddy and Little Sister is killed by it when he strikes a girl in a Big Daddy's presence. Most strikingly, Beauvoir's description of the child, who lives in a "serious world" of values given by adults and discovers freedom only in the crisis of adolescence, is an exact account of Jack, chronologically a child of a few years in an adult's body. Rand and Beauvoir were near-contemporaries, both writing about freedom in the 1940s. Rand's freedom is atomistic; Beauvoir's is relational. *BioShock* adjudicates for Beauvoir.

V.7 The Feminist Utopian Archive

Mary Wollstonecraft argued that women were kept in a perpetual childhood by being denied education and the exercise of reason, praised for an "innocence" that was merely ignorance (Wollstonecraft 1792). The Little Sisters are girls held in perpetual childhood by conditioning, and the good ending's first image of their freedom is education.

Charlotte Perkins Gilman's *Herland* (1915) imagined an all-female society that reproduces by parthenogenesis and organizes its entire civilization around collective motherhood. It is also a eugenic utopia, in which the reproduction of the unfit is

suppressed, and recent scholarship has made Gilman's eugenics central to any reading of first-wave feminist utopianism (Nadkarni 2014). Herland and Rapture are mirror images: a female utopia of the mother and a male utopia of the self, both of which control reproduction to perfect a population. The Little Sisters' production of ADAM is a parthenogenesis without will, reproduction without sex in the service of men.

Margaret Atwood's *The Handmaid's Tale* (1985) reduced women to reproductive function in a theocracy. Gilead and Rapture are ideological antipodes, one devout and one godless, one collectivist in its piety and one individualist in its greed, and they converge on the same body. Atwood's *Oryx and Crake* (2003) is Rapture's nearest literary neighbour: a corporate biotechnological dystopia of spliced creatures and engineered posthumans, a narrator manipulated by a genius, and a girl trafficked as a child into an economy of consumption. Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Dispossessed* (1974), subtitled *An Ambiguous Utopia*, set a propertarian world against an anarchist one in which women do science as equals, and remains feminist science fiction's most rigorous answer to Rand. Marge Piercy's *Woman on the Edge of Time* (1976), following Firestone, moved gestation into brooders and gave every child three co-mothers of any sex; *BioShock* shows the same technologies under propertarian ownership.

The archive's origin is Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus* (1818), whose subtitle names Rapture's research district. Victor Frankenstein creates life without a woman, and his creature reproaches him: "I ought to be thy Adam; but I am rather the fallen angel." Ellen Moers read the novel as a birth myth, Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar as a revision of *Paradise Lost*, and Anne Mellor as a critique of a masculine science that usurps female reproduction (Moers 1976; Gilbert and Gubar 1979; Mellor 1988). Jack is the creature, made without a mother's choice by men in a facility named for Prometheus, an Adam who becomes a fallen angel. Victor destroys the female creature he had begun, fearing what she would choose; Rapture makes its female creatures and allows them to choose nothing. That Shelley was Wollstonecraft's daughter makes the genealogy exact: the feminist critique of masculine creation begins in a single household.

V.8 Critical Limits: Disability, Queerness, and the Child

A feminist reading must also read against the game. Its horror aesthetic equates disfigurement with depravity, in the splicers' lesions and the bandaged faces of Steinman's patients. Rosemarie Garland-Thomson's analysis of the disabled body as freakish spectacle and Alison Kafer's critique of the "curative imaginary," which assumes that a desirable future is one without disability, expose the ableist axis on which both Rapture's enhancement market and its monsters depend (Garland-Thomson 1997; Kafer 2013). Sander Cohen's coding as a homicidal aesthete draws on a long lineage associating queerness with decadent cruelty, the lineage Eve

Kosofsky Sedgwick's work on the epistemology of the closet taught criticism to see (Sedgwick 1990).

The game's ethical horizon, finally, is the Child. Lee Edelman's critique of "reproductive futurism" argued that politics is organized around the figure of the Child as the unquestionable ground of value (Edelman 2004). The good ending's images of the girls' freedom, graduation, marriage, children and at last a gathering around Jack's deathbed, form what Sara Ahmed calls a happiness script, a sequence of approved milestones (Ahmed 2010). The only freedom the game can picture for its daughters is entry into heteronormative adulthood, culminating in attendance upon the dying father. José Esteban Muñoz's account of queer utopia as a horizon not yet here (Muñoz 2009) points toward the alternative that Chapter VIII reconstructs: a relation among the girls themselves.

V.9 Conclusion

The moral choice asks what a man will do with a girl. The structure answers a different question: who sustains the city, who undoes its conditioning, who restores its life, and who ends its order. To each question the answer is a woman or a girl.

CHAPTER VI

VI

Between Two Deaths

Humanism, Transhumanism, Posthumanism

Rapture is built in the interval between two deaths, the death of God and the death of Man. The "Man" of its banner is a possessive humanism, and the game documents its failure; the alternative it glimpses is relational. This chapter tests the city against the principal humanisms of the Western tradition and against their critics.

VI.1 The Banner Between Two Deaths

In section 125 of *The Gay Science* (1882), Nietzsche's madman announces the death of God and names his listeners as its perpetrators. In the closing pages of *The Order of Things* (1966), Michel Foucault argued that "man," as the object and subject of the human sciences, is an invention of recent date that may be nearing its end, and he imagined that figure effaced like a face sketched in sand at the edge of the sea. Ryan's banner stands exactly between the two events. It ratifies the first death and refuses to imagine the second. Rapture's site turns Foucault's image into architecture. The city of Man stands not at the edge of the sea but beneath it, and the sea is what perpetually breaks in: the leaks, the floods, the weight of water on glass that the player never stops hearing.

Humanism is plural, and Rapture tests each version. Renaissance humanism celebrated self-fashioning; Enlightenment humanism, autonomy and dignity; nineteenth-century secular humanism, the reclamation for Man of what had been projected onto God; existentialist humanism, the absence of any human essence prior to choice; postwar institutional humanism, the universal rights proclaimed in 1948. The

Universal Declaration of Human Rights opens by affirming that every human being is born free and equal in dignity and rights. Jack fails both premises. He was manufactured rather than born, and conditioned rather than free.

VI.2 Kant: Dignity Against Price

Kant's *Groundwork* (1785) distinguishes, within the kingdom of ends, between what has a price, which can be replaced by an equivalent, and what has a dignity, which is raised above all price and admits no equivalent. Rapture is the city in which everything has a price: the genome, the dead, the city's children. Kant's essay on enlightenment (1784) defined it as humanity's exit from a self-incurred immaturity, the inability to use one's own understanding without another's direction, and took as its motto Horace's *sapere aude*. Jack's immaturity is not self-incurred. It was manufactured, and his understanding is directed by another's voice by design.

Rand regarded Kant as her chief philosophical adversary and, in her late essays, judged him the most destructive figure in the history of thought. Rapture vindicates Kant against her. The Formula of Humanity, which forbids treating persons merely as means, is precisely what the city violates at every level, and Tenenbaum's turn is a return to it.

VI.3 Sartre's Paper-Knife

In *Existentialism Is a Humanism* (1946), Sartre illustrates the difference between artifacts and persons with a paper-knife. The artisan conceives the knife, its purpose and its method of manufacture before producing it; for the artifact, essence precedes existence. If no God conceives human beings in advance, then for them existence precedes essence: a person first exists, then defines himself through his choices, and is nothing other than what he makes of himself. Hence Sartre's humanism of radical responsibility, in which human beings are condemned to be free.

Jack is a man made like a paper-knife. His purpose, to reach Ryan, to kill him and to open the city's genetic locks, was conceived before his existence by artisans who commissioned, accelerated and conditioned him. This thesis calls him the *paper-knife subject*: a person whose essence was fixed before his existence began. Sartre's humanism rests on the absence of a designer. Rapture abolished God and installed designers, so that the existentialist premise fails not because of theology but because of commerce. The game asks whether a paper-knife can become a man, and it answers with a qualification Sartre's lecture does not contemplate: not by self-assertion alone, but through another's intervention, the antidote and the care that Tenenbaum supplies.

Sartre's own later thought points the same way. The *Critique of Dialectical Reason*, published in 1960, the year of Jack's arrival, introduced three concepts that describe Rapture's endgame closely. The *practico-inert* is matter worked by past human action

that now constrains present freedom: the ruined city whose vending machines still sell, whose loudspeakers still broadcast, whose turrets still fire. *Seriality* is the condition of a plurality of isolated, interchangeable individuals united only by an external object, like strangers waiting for a bus: the splicers. The *group-in-fusion* is the sudden transformation of a series into a group through common action against a common threat; Sartre's example is the crowd that took the Bastille. Chapter VIII reads the ending through this last concept.

VI.4 Heidegger: Humanism and Enframing

Heidegger's "Letter on Humanism" (written 1946, published 1947) answered Sartre by arguing that every humanism presupposes an interpretation of the human as a rational animal, and so fails to think what is distinctive in human existence; humanism, on this account, does not set the dignity of the human high enough. More pertinent to Rapture is his lecture "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954). The essence of modern technology, Heidegger argued, is *Gestell*, enframing, a mode of revealing in which everything appears as *Bestand*, standing-reserve, a stock available for ordering and use. The danger becomes extreme when human beings themselves are revealed as standing-reserve, at the very moment they imagine themselves lords of the earth.

Rapture is enframing made into a city. The slug, the sea, the forest, the dead and the city's conscripted children all appear as stock, and Ryan's Great Chain is the image of a world revealed entirely as resource. Ryan believes himself the earth's lord at the moment his city is converting him, too, into a reserve: a genetic key to be used by another.

VI.5 Arendt: The Human Condition at Depth

The prologue to Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) begins with the launch of Sputnik in 1957 and with the relief, voiced in the press, that humanity had taken a first step toward escaping the earth. Arendt read in that relief a rebellion against human existence as it has been given, a gift from nowhere, and a wish to exchange it for something of human making; she noted in the same breath the scientific ambition to create life artificially and to produce improved human beings. Rapture is Sputnik pointed downward: the same flight from the given, taken into the depths rather than the sky.

Arendt's tripartite analysis of the active life fits the city closely. *Labour* is the cyclical activity that sustains biological life, endlessly repeated, consumed as fast as it is produced, leaving nothing durable behind. *Work* is fabrication, the making of a durable world by homo faber, who treats everything, eventually including himself, as a means. *Action* is the capacity of plural equals to begin something new in speech and deed, the substance of political life. Rapture contains labour in abundance, in the looping circuits

of its gatherers, and work on a heroic scale, in Ryan's architecture. It contains no action: no public realm, no plurality, no speech among equals, only broadcast, command and transaction. Arendt warned that homo faber's instrumentalism ends by degrading every end into a means. Rapture is that degradation completed.

Arendt's central political category is natality, the capacity to begin, grounded in the fact that each human being enters the world as a newcomer; she returned repeatedly to Augustine's sentence *Initium ut esset homo creatus est*, that a beginning be made, man was created (Augustine, *City of God* XII). Jack's entry into the world was not a beginning. It was a production run, and his life an itinerary written in advance. Because the Vita-Chambers reconstitute him after every death, he also stands outside mortality. He lies beyond both of the great existential horizons of twentieth-century thought, Heidegger's being-toward-death and Arendt's natality. The good ending restores both. Jack grows old and dies, and he dies among those whose rescue gave them back the capacity to begin.

VI.6 The Designed Person

Jürgen Habermas's *The Future of Human Nature* (2003) argued against a market-driven regime of genetic enhancement on the ground that it would damage the ethical self-understanding of the species. A person whose characteristics were chosen by another, Habermas contended, may be unable to regard herself as the undivided author of her own life; the designer's intentions remain irreversibly present in her, and the reciprocity on which relations among free and equal persons depend is quietly broken. Jack is Habermas's scenario in its purest form. He was altered physically and conditioned psychologically, and the asymmetry between designer and designed is absolute: the designer's voice speaks inside him.

Michael Sandel's *The Case against Perfection* (2007), published in the same year as *BioShock*, located the moral problem of enhancement less in its risks than in the aspiration it expresses: a drive to mastery, a "hyperagency" that seeks to remake nature, human nature included, to fit our purposes. Against it Sandel set an ethic of giftedness and, borrowing a phrase from William F. May, an openness to the unbidden. Point Prometheus is hyperagency institutionalized. Sandel and Francis Fukuyama, whose *Our Posthuman Future* (2002) defended a shared human nature as the ground of equal dignity, both served on the President's Council on Bioethics, whose report *Beyond Therapy* (2003) framed the American enhancement debate in the years when *BioShock* was conceived and when stem-cell research was among the most contested questions in American politics. The opposing position bears a name its defenders chose deliberately. Nicholas Agar's *Liberal Eugenics* (2004) argued that enhancement is acceptable when the choice is left to individuals within a neutral liberal state rather than imposed by government, and Allen Buchanan and his co-authors had argued in *From Chance to Choice* (2000) that justice may require, rather than forbid, some genetic intervention.

The German title of Habermas's book posed the question on which the whole debate turned: *Auf dem Weg zu einer liberalen Eugenik?*, on the way to a liberal eugenics? Rapture is the answer to that question in its market form: liberal eugenics with the state removed and the choice priced, resting on a consent that takes the form Chapter III analysed, the courteous imperative.

Peter Sloterdijk's "Rules for the Human Zoo" (1999) provoked Germany's most public postwar argument about genetic selection. Sloterdijk argued that classical humanism had been a technology of taming, the cultivation of human beings through reading, and that biotechnology would replace letters with direct intervention; the question it raised was who would breed whom. His word was *Züchtung*, breeding, and his reference point was Plato's *Statesman*, which figures the ruler as a keeper of the human herd who must weave its temperaments together. Critics heard in the vocabulary an echo of National Socialist racial hygiene, and the controversy that followed in the German press in the autumn of 1999 drew in Habermas, whose book on the future of human nature was in part a reply (Sloterdijk 2009; Habermas 2003). Rapture enacts the transition Sloterdijk described. Ryan's humanism is literary, a matter of speeches, posters and banners; ADAM supersedes it by acting on bodies directly. And Rapture is a human zoo in the most literal sense available: a population kept behind glass in an engineered habitat, on display to the sea. In Rapture, moreover, Sloterdijk's question has an exact answer. Men commission the shaping of girls; the girls produce the substance that reshapes men; and the founder himself is reproduced without his knowledge, the embryo of his son purchased and grown into the instrument of his death. Who breeds whom? In Rapture, everyone is bred by someone who owns the result.

VI.7 The Eugenic Continuum

Rapture's science has a pedigree, and the game names it. Francis Galton coined the word *eugenics* in 1883 for the project of improving the human stock by controlling who reproduces (Galton 1883). In the United States the project became law. Charles Davenport's Eugenics Record Office at Cold Spring Harbor, founded in 1910, supplied its data; Harry Laughlin drafted a model sterilization statute; and in *Buck v. Bell* (1927) the Supreme Court upheld the compulsory sterilization of Carrie Buck, a young woman the state had classified as feebleminded on evidence later shown to be groundless (Lombardo 2008). By the time such laws fell into disuse, more than sixty thousand Americans had been sterilized under them (Kevles 1985). Germany's Law for the Prevention of Hereditarily Diseased Offspring of 1933 drew on the American model and led to the forced sterilization of some four hundred thousand people (Kühl 1994; Proctor 1988). From 1939 the regime moved from preventing births to killing. Its programmes of so-called euthanasia murdered disabled children and adults in the tens

of thousands; their personnel and methods passed into the extermination camps; and in the camps physicians experimented on prisoners (Friedlander 1995; Lifton 1986).

Tenenbaum's history places ADAM directly downstream of that lineage. The geneticist who made the Little Sisters learned her science assisting experiments on the imprisoned. The game does not present Rapture as an aberration from modern biology but as one of its possible continuations, and the continuation it imagines is instructive. Rapture keeps the eugenic goal, the improvement of human capacities, and abolishes the eugenic state. Selection is no longer imposed by courts and ministries; it is purchased. The result is not the end of coercion but its relocation. Enhancement is bought by those who can pay; disability and disfigurement are produced as by-products of the market and then stigmatized as monstrosity; and the children of the poorest families are taken as the raw material of the whole system.

Postwar humanism was not innocent of this history. Julian Huxley, who gave transhumanism its name, served as the first Director-General of UNESCO. In the document setting out the organization's philosophy, drafted in 1946, the year Rapture opened, he argued that although a radical eugenic policy would remain politically impossible for many years, it was important that eugenic questions be examined so that what was then unthinkable might at least become thinkable (Huxley 1947). From 1959 to 1962 he was President of the Eugenics Society. The institution charged with rebuilding the humanist project after the war was led, at its founding, by a man determined to keep the eugenic project alive within it. Rapture is the place where those two inheritances, humanism and eugenics, meet without the restraints that law and catastrophe had placed on them.

The liberal eugenics debate of the early twenty-first century inherited the same question in a new idiom. Its defenders insisted on the difference between state coercion and individual choice (Agar 2004; Buchanan et al. 2000). Its critics in disability studies answered with the "expressivist" objection: practices that select against disabled lives express a judgement about the worth of those already living with disability, whatever the intentions of the individuals who choose (Parens and Asch 1999). Rapture dramatizes both sides. The choice is real, and it is a market choice; and the judgement the market expresses about bodies that fail its standard is written on every splicer's face. The game's own horror aesthetic, which Chapter V criticized for equating disfigurement with depravity, participates in the judgement it otherwise exposes.

VI.8 The Two Huxleys

Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932) imagined a society that manufactures its citizens in hatcheries, sorts them into castes before birth, conditions them through phrases repeated during sleep, and pacifies them with a drug, soma. Its outsider, John the Savage, was born outside the system and enters it as a stranger. Jack seems to be the Savage, the outsider who arrives from the surface, and turns out to be the hatchery's

product; his conditioning phrase is a waking version of Huxley's sleep-teaching, and ADAM and EVE are a soma that disfigures rather than soothes. Huxley's World Controller chooses stability and happiness over truth and freedom. Ryan chose freedom over stability and secured neither.

Two details of Huxley's hatcheries sharpen the parallel. Embryos destined for the lower castes are deliberately impaired, starved of oxygen and dosed with alcohol in their blood-surrogate, so that they will be fit only for the labour assigned to them: disposability is manufactured before birth. And in the Neo-Pavlovian Conditioning Rooms, infants of the Delta caste are taught to recoil from books and flowers by alarm bells and electric shocks, so that aversion becomes reflex. Rapture repeats both. The Little Sisters are fitted to a single function before they are deployed, and their conditioning, like the Deltas', makes the unbearable feel natural; Jack's first plasmid, the electric shock of Electro Bolt, places the instrument of the Conditioning Rooms in the conditioned man's own hand. Bokanovsky's Process, which divides a single egg into dozens of identical workers, has its echo in the interchangeable seriality of Rapture's gatherers and guardians.

Julian Huxley, Aldous's brother, gave wide currency to the word *transhumanism* in a 1957 essay proposing that humanity might transcend itself by applying science to its own nature; he was also, as the previous section showed, among the most prominent eugenicists of his generation. Rapture at its height sits exactly between the brothers, between the satirist of engineered humanity and its prophet. Nick Bostrom's later defence of posthuman dignity argued that enhancement and dignity are compatible (Bostrom 2005). Rapture's reply is that the decisive question is not whether enhancement is compatible with dignity in principle but who pays for it in practice. In Rapture the price is paid by those who cannot refuse.

VI.9 Man2: Wynter and the Overrepresentation of the Human

Sylvia Wynter argued that Western modernity has twice redefined the human in a form that overrepresents one group as if it were humanity as such (Wynter 2003). "Man1," the rational political subject of the Renaissance state, gave way in the nineteenth century to "Man2," a bio-economic subject understood through natural selection and market competition, whose negative pole is the poor, the colonized and the racialized, classed as unfit. Ryan's banner is Man2 compressed into a single word. Its "Man" is an organism competing in a market, measured by productive and genetic fitness; the game's very title fuses the two halves of Wynter's formula. Rapture's population is overwhelmingly white, its few figures of colour are marginal or caricatured, and its "Man" is the white, male, propertied producer whom Wynter exposes as a part masquerading as the whole. Frantz Fanon's call, at the close of *The Wretched of the Earth* (1961), for a new humanism built by those whom European "Man" had excluded,

rather than an imitation of Europe, belongs to the same constellation and marks the path the game does not take.

Wynter's term for the negative pole of Man2 is the *dysselected*: those whom the bio-economic order classes as unfit by nature and poor by desert, so that their poverty appears as the verdict of selection rather than the product of a social order. It is the category of *Buck v. Bell* and of every sterilization ward. Rapture has its dysselected, and it knows where they live. The Little Sisters are drawn from Fontaine's orphanage and the city's poorest families, the population of Apollo Square's poorhouses, the class Ryan's ideology could explain only as failure. The children of the dysselected become the raw material from which the selected buy their improvement. That is Wynter's argument rendered as an economy, and it is why the game's critique of Objectivism cannot be separated from a critique of the racial and class order that the word Man conceals.

VI.10 Posthumanism: Haraway, Braidotti, Hayles, and the Sea

Donna Haraway's cyborg manifesto (1985) proposed the cyborg, a hybrid of organism and machine, as a figure for feminist politics because it lacks an origin story in the Western sense: it has no Eden to recognize, no dust to return to, and no use for the Oedipal family drama. The splicers are anti-cyborgs. Their technology is named for Eden, their society reenacts the drama of father and son, and their founder rules through an origin myth. Haraway also observed that cyborgs are the illegitimate offspring of militarism and patriarchal capitalism, and that illegitimate offspring are often unfaithful to their origins. The Little Sisters are such offspring: products of Rapture's patriarchal capitalism who prove, at the end, unfaithful to the man who exploited them. Haraway's later critique of "gene fetishism," the treatment of the gene as a self-sufficient source of value (Haraway 1997), names ADAM's ideology, and her call to make kin by affinity rather than by lineage (Haraway 2016) names the alternative. In a city whose only acknowledged inheritance is the genetic key that passes from Ryan to his son, the Sisters are the only kin made by affinity.

Haraway's most pointed image belongs here. OncoMouse, a mouse engineered to develop cancer for laboratory research and, in 1988, the first animal to be patented, appears in *Modest_Witness* as a creature Haraway insists on calling kin: a sister in suffering whose existence, made for others' use, obligates relation rather than mere use (Haraway 1997). The Little Sisters are Rapture's OncoMice, living organisms re-engineered as a proprietary platform for research and production. Haraway's insistence on calling the patented creature a sister is the posthumanist ethic this thesis follows when it reads the girls as a sorority rather than a supply.

Rosi Braidotti criticized the Vitruvian Man of classical humanism as a white, male, able-bodied standard posing as universal, and proposed an affirmative ethics centred on *zoe*, the generative vitality of life, rather than on human exceptionalism (Braidotti

2013). Where Agamben saw in *zoe* the bare life captured by sovereignty, Braidotti sees a generative force that sovereignty seeks to capture but cannot exhaust. N. Katherine Hayles showed how cybernetic thought imagined information as separable from its material embodiment (Hayles 1999). ADAM applies that dream to the body, treating the genome as rewritable code; the game's ruined bodies are the embodiment the dream forgets.

The sea is the last term. Rachel Carson's oceanic writing and Stacy Alaimo's feminist account of trans-corporeality treat bodies and environments as continuous rather than separate, and the emerging blue humanities treat the ocean as an agent rather than a backdrop (Alaimo 2010; Gillis 2013). Rapture's sea is an agent. It presses, leaks and floods; it supplies the organism that rewrites human bodies; it is, in Foucault's image, what erases the face of Man.

VI.11 Conclusion: Possessive Humanism and Its Alternative

Rapture's failure is not the failure of humanism as such. It is the failure of possessive humanism, in which the human is defined as proprietor of himself and his capacities, and dignity collapses into price. The alternative the game glimpses is relational, and it has a history in the same constellation. Beauvoir argued that one cannot will oneself free without willing others free. Arendt located freedom in plurality and natality. Simone Weil, in *The Need for Roots* (1949), argued that obligations are prior to rights, since a right is effective only when someone acknowledges an obligation toward it, and that uprootedness is the gravest disease of human societies, because the uprooted go on to uproot others. Rapture is a city of the uprooted, severed from earth, history and community, and it uproots children. Weil's essay on the *Iliad* had described force as what turns a person into a thing (Weil 1945). The humanism the game cannot fully articulate, but whose outline it traces, is one in which obligations to the most vulnerable come before the rights of the strongest. It is also a humanism obliged to reckon with its own entanglement in the eugenic project, from Galton's coinage to the founding philosophy of UNESCO, rather than imagining that the critique of Rapture leaves the humanist tradition clean.

CHAPTER VII

VII

Ludic Objectivism

Procedure, Reward, and the Last Randian

BioShock's form is more Randian than its content is anti-Randian. Its reward architecture compensates mercy, so that virtue pays and the just choice coincides with the profitable one, which is exactly Rand's thesis of the harmony of rational interests. The celebrated dissonance between rules and story is better described as complicity, and the one act that escapes the game's economy is the one act the player cannot perform.

VII.1 Dissonance Reconsidered

Hocking's diagnosis had two parts. The rules, he argued, reward the self-interest that the story condemns; and the story, at its turning point, compels the player to keep obeying, which contradicts the freedom the rules seemed to offer (Hocking 2007). Many critics added a third observation: after Ryan's death, when Jack is supposedly freed, the game goes on assigning objectives exactly as before, now in Tenenbaum's voice, so that liberation changes nothing in the form of play.

Jesper Juul's account of games as half-real, a fiction wrapped around rules that genuinely operate, explains why such gaps are felt so sharply: the player meets the rules directly and the fiction only through imagination (Juul 2005). Ian Bogost's theory of procedural rhetoric holds that rules make arguments, persuading through the processes they require the player to enact (Bogost 2007). Alexander Galloway proposed that to play a game is to learn and execute its algorithm, so that every game is an allegory of the control it simulates (Galloway 2006). Read together, these accounts suggest that the dissonance thesis asks the wrong question. It assumes that rules and

fiction ought to agree and finds that they do not. This chapter argues that, at the level of ideology, they agree perfectly.

VII.2 The Economy of Mercy

The decisive procedure is the choice between harvesting and rescuing a Little Sister. Harvesting, which kills her, yields roughly twice the immediate ADAM of a rescue. Rescuing frees her and yields less, but Tenenbaum compensates rescues with periodic gifts of ADAM and of unique tonics, so that over the whole game the material difference between the two paths is modest. The endings complete the ledger: consistent mercy is rewarded with the ending the game marks as good.

The structure has a precise doctrinal name. Rand held that there are no genuine conflicts of interest among rational agents, because the trader principle guarantees that the just act is also the advantageous one (Rand 1964). *BioShock*'s economy of mercy proves her right within its own walls. The player who rescues loses almost nothing, gains a better ending, and is told that he has chosen well. Rescue is the rational, self-interested strategy for any player who values completion. The game condemns Rand in its story and vindicates her in its arithmetic.

This thesis names the result *ludic Objectivism*: the condition of a reward architecture that functions as a value-for-value economy, so that every act, including every apparent act of altruism, is an exchange. The term is not meant to single out *BioShock*. Most games that score, level and unlock are trader economies, and the trader principle is close to the native grammar of reward. *BioShock* is distinctive because it builds a narrative critique of that grammar while running on it.

Both paths pay, and the interface shows which side of the ledger it wants seen. Harvest pays at once, in ADAM; rescue pays later, in gifts and in a better ending. The visual rhetoric of the harvest is exact: the act itself takes place at the edge of the frame, while its yield registers on the interface as a number. The design reproduces in miniature the concealment Marx found in the commodity form. The violence that produces the value is kept out of view, and the value is displayed as if it had produced itself.

VII.3 Kant's Prudent Merchant

Kant's *Groundwork* distinguishes acting in conformity with duty from acting from duty through the example of a merchant who never overcharges an inexperienced customer. The merchant is honest because honesty serves his business; his conduct is correct, and it has no moral worth (Kant 1785). The rescuing player is Kant's prudent merchant. His mercy conforms to duty, but the design guarantees that it also serves his interest, and neither the player nor the game can know whether he would rescue if mercy cost him everything. A choice system that rewards the right choice cannot represent the moral

worth of choosing it. Sicart's worry that such systems reduce ethics to resource management (Sicart 2009) is confirmed here in its strongest form: the problem is not that the moral choice is computed but that it is compensated.

VII.4 Omelas Without Walking Away

Le Guin's parable has a feature that discussions of it often neglect. The ones who walk away from Omelas gain nothing. They leave behind the city's happiness, beauty and abundance and set out for a place the narrator cannot describe. Their refusal is costly by definition. *BioShock*'s rescuers walk away from Rapture's Omelas and are paid for it. The game cannot let the player refuse the city's bargain without compensating the refusal, and so it never tests the player's ethics. It tests the player's prudence.

Robert Nozick's experience machine asked whether one would plug into a device supplying any experience one desired, and answered that one would not, because people want actually to do things and to be certain kinds of persons, not merely to have the experience of doing and being (Nozick 1974). The twist of *BioShock* makes the player discover that his doing had been an experience of doing. The economy of mercy extends the lesson. Even the player's goodness was an experience of goodness, priced and paid.

VII.5 The Instruments of the Player

The research camera rewards Jack for photographing his enemies with combat bonuses against them. Susan Sontag argued that to photograph is to appropriate what is photographed and to convert experience into a collection (Sontag 1977). In Fort Frolic the camera is conscripted into Sander Cohen's art: Jack must eliminate Cohen's former disciples and photograph them to complete the artist's composition. The player becomes the aesthete's assistant. Walter Benjamin closed his essay on the work of art in the age of its technological reproducibility by warning that fascism aestheticizes politics, and that humanity's self-alienation had reached a point at which it could experience its own destruction as aesthetic pleasure (Benjamin 2002). Fort Frolic stages that warning as a level, and the camera makes the player its accomplice.

The rest of the apparatus is commercial. Jack buys supplies from the Circus of Values and plasmids from the Gatherer's Garden; he hacks the city's machines through a puzzle that has the player rerouting their plumbing; he upgrades his weapons at stations named Power to the People, a revolutionary slogan converted into a weapons kiosk. The commodification of revolt is the last refinement of the market Ryan built: even the language of insurrection is for sale.

One plasmid closes the circle. Hypnotize Big Daddy allows the player to condition a Big Daddy into serving as his own protector, redirecting to the player the bond Suchong engineered between guardian and girl. The courteous imperative passes into the

player's hands: the conditioned man becomes a conditioner, and the player stands to a Big Daddy as Fontaine stood to Jack. The game's systems invite the player to reproduce, as a tactic, the very relation its story condemns as the city's original sin.

The Vita-Chambers complete the picture by removing death. A player who cannot die cannot risk anything, and in Hegel's terms cannot win recognition. The player of *BioShock* is a sovereign consumer who risks nothing and is master of nothing.

Freud's *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) began from a puzzle: patients compelled to repeat painful experiences rather than remember them, and a small boy who mastered his mother's absences by throwing a spool away and pulling it back, *fort* and *da*, gone and here. The Vita-Chamber mechanizes that repetition. Death becomes a return to the same corridor, the same ambush, the same encounter, repeated until it is mastered, and Jesper Juul has shown how fully the pleasure of games depends on such cycles of failure and return (Juul 2013). Rapture is a city of repetition in Freud's darker sense as well: its audio diaries replay the last moments of the dead, and its ruined machines go on performing their functions for no one. The Little Sisters' circuit is repetition too, of another kind. The player repeats in order to master; the girls repeat because they are not permitted to stop. The same structure is play for one and labour for the other, which is the difference Beauvoir drew between transcendence and immanence.

VII.6 After the Twist

Critics have objected that, after Ryan's death, the game resumes guiding the player through objectives exactly as before, so that the form of bondage persists after the bond is broken. This thesis reads the persistence as the work's unconscious truth rather than its failure. Liberation from one voice consists in following another. Freedom, in *BioShock*, is not the absence of guidance but a change in its ethical character, from command disguised as courtesy to care. Atlas and Tenenbaum are formally identical: both are radio voices assigning tasks. Their difference is that one uses Jack while the other works through Jack on behalf of the girls. The game cannot represent that difference procedurally, because its procedures cannot tell care from command; it can only narrate it. The limit belongs to the medium, and the game lets the player feel it.

VII.7 The Act That Cannot Be Played

The final defeat of Fontaine is completed in a cinematic. The player weakens him, the Little Sisters end him, and the camera is no longer the player's to direct. The single act in *BioShock* that escapes both Rapture's economy and the player's agency is therefore the act the player cannot perform. Procedural rhetoric reaches its limit here. What liberates, in this game, cannot be proceduralized as reward, because anything the player

does is already an exchange. The decisive deed belongs to others and takes place outside play.

VII.8 Conclusion: The Last Randian

The dissonance between rules and story is better called complicity. The player, interpellated as a sovereign chooser, discovers first that his choices were commands and then, if he reflects on the economy of mercy, that even his virtue was a transaction. Rapture's last Randian is not Ryan, who died for a principle. It is the player, who did the right thing because it paid.

CHAPTER VIII

VIII

The Sororal Strike

The Daughters of Atlas

The thesis can now be stated whole. Rapture's sovereign individual is a parasitic formation; the courteous imperative is its grammar; the necro-maternal economy is its base; ludic Objectivism is its form; and the sororal strike is its negation. This chapter assembles the argument around the question Rand's novel made famous and the answer Rapture gives it.

VIII.1 The Strike and Its Inversion

Atlas Shrugged was drafted under the working title *The Strike*. Its plot is a withdrawal: the men of the mind, led by John Galt, stop producing, and the world they leave behind collapses, proving by subtraction who had been holding it up. The novel's argument rests on a claim about bearing. Civilization stands on the shoulders of its industrialists, as the sky stands on the shoulders of the Titan.

Feminist political economy has its own theory of the strike, and it makes the opposite claim about who bears the world. The Wages for Housework campaign of the 1970s argued that unwaged reproductive labour sustains every economy and that its withdrawal would reveal its indispensability (Dalla Costa and James 1972; Federici 1975). On 24 October 1975 the women of Iceland tested the proposition. Around nine in ten of them stopped work, paid and unpaid, for a day; offices, schools and much of daily life came to a halt. Five years later Iceland elected Vigdís Finnbogadóttir, the first woman in the world to be chosen head of state by direct popular vote. The North Atlantic, the ocean in which *BioShock* sinks its city, was the scene of the twentieth

century's clearest demonstration of who holds up the sky. The International Women's Strike of 2017 renewed the tactic across dozens of countries.

The sororal strike is the inversion of Galt's. Galt's strike withdraws production to prove that producers carry the world. The sororal strike withdraws reproduction and reveals that the producers were carried.

VIII.2 The Strike in the Game

The sororal strike operates in *BioShock* at two levels. The first is cumulative. Every rescue removes a girl from the ADAM economy, and a player who rescues every Little Sister performs, over the length of the game, the progressive withdrawal of the city's reproductive base; Tenenbaum's stated aim is to end the trade altogether. The game codes this as mercy. Political economy codes it as a strike.

The second level is the climax. In the Proving Grounds, Jack, wearing the armour of a Big Daddy, escorts the Little Sisters toward Fontaine, who has spliced himself into a gilded, Titan-like giant: the counterfeit Atlas at last takes the shape of the statue. Jack weakens him by drawing the ADAM out of him with one of the girls' own syringes, so that the protagonist defeats the false father with an instrument of the daughters' labour. Then the Little Sisters converge on the fallen Fontaine and finish him with those same instruments. The moment is invariant across every ending. It is not conditional on the player's moral choices, and it is not interactive.

VIII.3 The Daughters of Atlas

The mythographic tradition gave the Titan Atlas daughters, among them the Hesperides, who guard the golden apples of immortality in a garden at the western edge of the world, and Calypso, the nymph of the far ocean. *BioShock*'s ending enacts a myth the tradition never wrote: the daughters of Atlas overthrow a false Atlas. Fontaine took the Titan's name and bore nothing. The girls, who bore the city's entire economy, end him.

The question Rand's novel attached to its hero, and which *BioShock* transfers to its impostor, therefore receives an answer. Who is Atlas? The bearer of Rapture's world was never the industrialist, never the founder and never the man who borrowed the Titan's name. Atlas is a little girl. More precisely, Atlas is the daughters, in the plural, because the bearing was always collective.

VIII.4 Theorizing the Act

Three frames illuminate the ending. The first is Sartre's *group-in-fusion*. Throughout the game the Little Sisters appear as a series in Sartre's sense, interchangeable units of a serial economy, each paired with her own guardian and confined to her own circuit. In the final scene the series fuses into a group through common action against a common threat, which is precisely the transformation Sartre located at the origin of every revolutionary collective.

The second is Walter Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921), which distinguishes mythic violence, which founds and preserves law, from a "divine" violence that destroys law without founding a new order (Benjamin 1996). The ending terminates Rapture's law of value, the order of extraction on which the city ran, and founds nothing in its place; the game passes directly to its epilogues. Benjamin's concept is notoriously difficult and has been subjected to searching critique, most influentially by Jacques Derrida (Derrida 1990). It is used here as an allegorical frame for the termination of an order, not as an endorsement of violence. Hannah Arendt's distinction between power, which arises whenever people act in concert, and violence, which is always instrumental (Arendt 1970), marks the ambivalence of the scene: the act is concerted, and its means are instruments.

The third frame is Haraway's. The cyborg, she wrote, is the illegitimate offspring of patriarchal capitalism, and such offspring are often unfaithful to their origins. Federici's insistence that the body is a site of resistance as well as of exploitation makes the same point in the language of political economy. The girls whom Rapture made into instruments of its economy become, at the end, the instrument of its undoing.

VIII.5 The Ambiguity of the Act

Honesty requires a complication. Are the girls free in this act? They are led to it by Jack in the paternal armour, on a plan devised by Tenenbaum, and whether their conditioning still operates is never settled. The act can be read as their first collective deed or as one more use of them as instruments, directed this time against the man who first used them. This thesis holds both readings and argues that the ambiguity is the work's honesty. *BioShock* cannot imagine the girls' freedom except at the edge of its own frame, in a cinematic the player cannot enter, after the paternal plot has done its work. The game points toward a freedom it cannot depict.

VIII.6 The Silence of the Daughters

Rapture remembers itself through recorded voices: Ryan's broadcasts, Atlas's transmissions, and the audio diaries of scientists, artists, socialites, smugglers and parents. The girls on whom the city lived leave almost no testimony of their own. They are spoken about by Tenenbaum and Suchong; spoken for by Atlas, who urges their harvest, and by Tenenbaum, who pleads for their rescue; and decided upon by Jack. In the good ending their lives are narrated by Tenenbaum. At no point in *BioShock* does a Little Sister give an account of what was done to her.

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's "Can the Subaltern Speak?" (1988) gives this silence its theoretical name. Spivak's argument is not that the subaltern woman literally cannot speak but that her speech cannot be heard within the structures that represent her, because those structures have already assigned her a part. Her emblem of the problem is the colonial rescue narrative, in which white men cast themselves as the rescuers of brown women from brown men: the intervention justifies itself by making the woman an object to be saved, and her own voice disappears between the rescuer and the oppressor. Lila Abu-Lughod later traced the same structure in the rhetoric of rescue that accompanied the war in Afghanistan (Abu-Lughod 2002). *BioShock*'s moral choice reproduces Spivak's structure with uncanny precision. Good men save girls from bad men, or harvest them; in either case the girls appear only as the objects of a decision between men, and the game's single moral question, what will you do with her, has no grammatical place for her answer.

Linda Alcoff's analysis of the problem of speaking for others supplies the ethical complement (Alcoff 1991). Speaking for the silenced is sometimes necessary, and it is never innocent: the speaker's location shapes what is said, and representation can reproduce the hierarchy it means to oppose. Tenenbaum's advocacy is the best the city offers, and the game is honest enough to make the advocate a former perpetrator, whose speech for the girls is also the speech of the woman who made them what they are.

Miranda Fricker's *Epistemic Injustice*, published in 2007, the year of *BioShock*'s release, distinguishes testimonial injustice, in which a speaker is given less credibility than she deserves because of prejudice, from hermeneutical injustice, in which a gap in the shared resources of interpretation leaves someone unable to make sense of her own experience or to communicate it (Fricker 2007). The Little Sisters suffer a hermeneutical injustice that was engineered. Their conditioning gives them a vocabulary, "angels" for the dead, "Mr. Bubbles" for their armoured guardian, "Daddy" for the man welded to their service, and that vocabulary was designed by their exploiters so that the experience of exploitation could not be recognized as such, by the girls or by anyone listening to them. This thesis names the condition *engineered hermeneutical injustice*: the

deliberate supply, to the victims of a system, of concepts that render their victimization unintelligible.

Saidiya Hartman's "Venus in Two Acts" (2008) confronts the same silence in the archive of the Atlantic slave trade, where girls who died aboard ship survive only as names in the records of those responsible for their deaths. Hartman asks how one can tell the story of a life that the archive preserves only in the language of its destruction, and she answers with a method she calls critical fabulation: a narration that works at the limits of the record, refusing both to invent a voice that would be one more appropriation and to repeat the violence by restaging it. The obligation to express the voice of the distressed is real, and so is the danger of ventriloquism. Hartman's method is the model this thesis follows. It does not invent speech for the Little Sisters. It reads the structure of the game for what the girls' situation says, and it locates their one act of expression where the game places it, at the end.

Hannah Arendt held that speech and action disclose who someone is, as distinct from what someone is, and that such disclosure requires a space of appearance among others (Arendt 1958). The girls are denied that disclosure from the beginning: everything said of them says what they are, a resource, a victim, a ward. Their collective act at the end is the only moment at which they appear as someone, and it is a deed without words. It can be misread, as Spivak's emblematic subaltern act was misread by those closest to it, as horror rather than testimony, the monstrous children of genre rather than the first statement of those whom the city had silenced. This thesis reads it as testimony.

VIII.7 Censorship and the Unshowable

Censorship is a theme of Rapture before it is a question about the game. Ryan's founding address promised a city in which the artist would not fear the censor. The city he governed treated scripture as contraband, executed smugglers, cut its citizens off from the surface, monopolized its public-address system and made its own propaganda the soundtrack of daily life. Sander Cohen, the artist Ryan most favoured, turned freedom from the censor into freedom from ethics, and Fort Frolic is the result. The promise that art would be free proved to mean that power would be free to decide which art, and whose speech, survived.

The game's Art Deco shares its imagery with Rockefeller Center, whose bronze Atlas the villain's final form recalls, and that imagery carries a history of censorship with it. In 1934 the Rockefellers had Diego Rivera's mural *Man at the Crossroads* destroyed in the lobby of the RCA Building after Rivera refused to remove a portrait of Lenin; Rivera repainted the composition in Mexico City as *Man, Controller of the Universe*. The visual vocabulary of capitalist triumph that *BioShock* inherits was secured, in its most prominent home, by the destruction of a work that dissented from it. Ryan's banner of

Man and Rivera's controller of the universe are rival answers to the same question, and the patron settled the dispute by demolition.

The game also censors itself, and its self-censorship is ethically double. The Little Sisters cannot be harmed by ordinary weapons; the only violence the player can do to them is the harvest, and the harvest is staged at the edge of the frame. These choices protect the work from the charge of making violence against children into play, and they reflect the real constraints of commercial classification under which a mature-rated game is sold. They also reproduce, at the level of the image, the concealment on which Rapture's economy depends. The city hid its girls in the walls; the game hides what is done to them at the edge of the screen; and in both cases what remains in view is the yield.

The double bind has no clean resolution, and critical tradition has named both of its horns. Susan Sontag warned that images of suffering can summon conscience and can also numb it, turning others' pain into spectacle for viewers who are not themselves at risk (Sontag 2003). Hartman's *Scenes of Subjection* (1997) declined to reproduce the most notorious descriptions of violence against the enslaved, because repeating them in the name of denunciation risks reenacting the violation and inviting the reader to consume it. Against both stands the demand that the distressed be seen and heard, and that suffering not be hidden for the comfort of those who profit from it. *BioShock* chooses concealment, and the choice can be read as restraint or as complicity. This thesis adopts Hartman's discipline for its own descriptions, keeping the harm done to the game's children non-graphic, while insisting, against the game's concealment, that the structure of that harm be named in full: the seizure, the implantation, the conditioning, the extraction and the silence.

VIII.8 Why Sororal

The Little Sisters' bond with one another is the only horizontal relation in Rapture. Every other relation is vertical: Ryan's ownership, Fontaine's manipulation, the Big Daddy's protection, Jack's choice, the player's ledger. *Sisterhood Is Powerful* was the title Robin Morgan gave her 1970 anthology of the women's liberation movement (Morgan 1970). bell hooks later criticized versions of sisterhood founded on shared victimhood and argued instead for a political solidarity among women that acknowledges difference and is built through commitment rather than presumed (hooks 1986). The sororal strike is solidarity in hooks's sense, not sameness: a bond formed in common action.

The term also answers Pateman. The classical social contract, she argued, is fraternal: the brothers overthrow the father's rule and secure among themselves the subordination of women (Pateman 1988). Rapture's history is a fraternal struggle in exactly this sense, a contest among men, Ryan, Fontaine and Jack, over the city and the

girls on whom it depends. Its ending is not fraternal. The sororal strike is what the fraternal contract excluded, returning as the force that ends it.

It answers Le Guin as well. Omelas offers two responses to the suffering child on whom the city's happiness rests: stay and accept, or walk away. The sororal strike is the third response the parable does not imagine, in which those on whom the city rests refuse to go on carrying it.

VIII.9 The Frame That Contains It

The endings re-contain the act. The good ending narrates the girls' freedom as a sequence of approved milestones that culminates at Jack's deathbed. The bad ending shows the city's weapons seized and turned outward, the girls' fate subordinated to Jack's appetite. Both return the narrative to Jack. The sororal act is bracketed on one side by the paternal plot that leads to it and on the other by the paternal endings that follow. *BioShock*'s unconscious is feminist; its frame is paternalist.

VIII.10 The Thesis Stated

Rapture's sovereign individual is a parasitic formation whose self-ownership exists only by feeding on hosts denied subjecthood (Chapters I and IV). His city's names confess it (Chapter II). His power speaks the courteous imperative, the grammar of consent as compulsion (Chapter III). His economy rests on the unwaged, conscripted labour of girls who recycle the dead into value (Chapter IV). His gender order makes protectors into property and turns the mother into the deprogrammer (Chapter V). His humanism is possessive, and its alternative relational (Chapter VI). His game, as played, ratifies the doctrine its story condemns (Chapter VII). And his order is ended not by a better individual but by a collective of those on whom he fed, who, denied testimony by the very concepts their conditioning supplied, speak once, in a deed without words. Who is Atlas? The daughters.

CODA



Beyond the Sea

The Daughter's Migration Toward Authorship

Read as a sequence, the series moves agency from father to daughter. Its first daughter is an object of choice; its second makes the final choice, shaped by the example of the man who protects her; its third authors the ending and then becomes the player's own point of view.

BioShock 2 (2K Marin, 2010), directed by Jordan Thomas, who had designed Fort Frolic, returns to Rapture in 1968 under a new ideologue. Sofia Lamb, a psychiatrist, preaches the dissolution of the self into a collective she calls the Family, an altruism as total as Ryan's egoism and its exact mirror image. The protagonist, Subject Delta, is one of the earliest Big Daddies, searching for Eleanor, Lamb's daughter, to whom he was once bonded. Lamb's collectivism, like Ryan's individualism, converges on the daughter: she means to make Eleanor the embodiment of the Family's future, a self without self-interest. The sequel's Big Sisters, former Little Sisters grown into armed enforcers, make visible what the first game's ending concealed, that children conditioned to serve an economy become its instruments of force as they grow. Eleanor's final choice depends on the moral example the player has set, so that the daughter learns her ethics by watching the father figure. The sequel completes Rapture's ideological diptych: two utopias, egoist and altruist, and one daughter whose selfhood both would sacrifice.

BioShock Infinite (Irrational Games, 2013) moves to Columbia, a floating city of 1912 governed by the prophet Zachary Comstock as a theocratic and white-nationalist fantasy of American exceptionalism. Its daughter, Elizabeth, is confined in a tower by Songbird, a mechanical guardian who reworks the Big Daddy as a jailer, while a

machine called the Siphon contains and drains her powers: the extraction of a young woman's capacities made explicit in the apparatus. The story's central secret is that Elizabeth is the protagonist Booker DeWitt's own daughter, sold in infancy by her own father to settle his gambling debts, a transaction that rhymes with Jack's purchase as an embryo and with Jasmine Jolene's sale of the embryo she carried. The city's science also rests on a woman's discovery. The physicist Rosalind Lutece, whose given name recalls Rosalind Franklin, made Columbia float, and Comstock appropriated her work. Daisy Fitzroy's insurgent Vox Populi, the counterpart of Atlas's uprising, shows a liberation movement reproducing the violence it opposes, a portrayal that critics have faulted for implying an equivalence between oppressor and oppressed. The ending belongs to Elizabeth. Having gained command of the city's possible worlds, she leads Booker back to the baptismal waters where he accepts his own undoing so that Comstock may never exist. The father consents to the daughter's design.

Infinite's treatment of its insurgent leader exposes the series' most persistent device. In one of its most disputed scenes, Daisy Fitzroy, the Black revolutionary who leads the Vox Populi, is shown on the point of killing a white child of the city's industrial elite, and Elizabeth kills her to prevent it. Critics charged that the scene turned a resistance movement against white supremacy into a threat to a white child, drawing a false equivalence between oppressor and oppressed. *Burial at Sea* later revised the scene, recasting Daisy's act as staged at the instigation of the Lutece twins, a revision that answered the charge only by making the Black revolutionary's agency belong to someone else. The threatened child is the series' recurring moral fulcrum, the figure on whom judgement turns, from the Little Sisters to Elizabeth herself, and the pattern confirms Edelman's diagnosis of the Child as the unquestioned ground of value (Edelman 2004). The series also returns, game after game, to the sale and seizure of children: Jack purchased as an embryo, Eleanor claimed by her mother for the Family, Elizabeth sold by her father. Across three ideologies the child is property, and the drama of each game is whether anyone will stop treating her that way.

Burial at Sea (2013–2014), Irrational's two-part expansion, returns to Rapture on the eve of its fall. In its second episode the player inhabits Elizabeth herself, and her actions are retroactively entangled with the chain of events that will bring Jack to the city. The daughter becomes both the playable subject and a hidden author of the first game's plot.

The arc runs from object of choice (the Little Sister, 2007), to a chooser formed by a father's example (Eleanor, 2010), to the author of the ending (Elizabeth, 2013), to the playable subject (Elizabeth, 2014). It is incomplete and compromised. Elizabeth's authorship is exercised largely on the father's behalf, and her final episode entangles her in the very plot of conditioning the first game exposed. Its direction nonetheless confirms the thesis. What *BioShock* could stage only in a cinematic at the edge of its frame, its successors move steadily toward the centre. Across three ideologies,

libertarian, collectivist and theocratic, the series returns to the same figure, the daughter whose capacities others seek to own, and each time it grants her a little more of the story.

CONCLUSION



Rapture's founding broadcast asked to whom the product of a man's labour belongs. This thesis has argued that the game's deeper question is the one Ryan never thought to ask: on whose labour the man himself was made.

Contributions

For the study of *BioShock*, the thesis relocates the work's centre of gravity from the chooser, whether Ryan, Jack or the player, to the substrate on which choosing depends: the Little Sisters, the Big Daddies, and the women who sustain and finally deprogramme the city. The girls appear here not as the occasion of a dilemma but as the economic and ethical base of the whole order. The argument complements, rather than replaces, the ideology-critique of Packer (2010) and the essays in Cuddy (2015), the aesthetic account of Tavinor (2009), and the interdisciplinary work collected in Aldred and Parker (2018).

For game studies, it proposes moving from "ludonarrative dissonance" to complicity. Choice systems that compensate virtue instantiate a *ludic Objectivism*, a value-for-value grammar of reward that ratifies Rand's harmony of interests whatever the story says. The analysis also marks a limit of procedural rhetoric: in *BioShock*, what liberates is precisely what cannot be played.

For feminist theory, it offers three instruments. The *courteous imperative* names consent as the form of compulsion and can be applied wherever agreement is structurally unrefusable: terms of service, nudges, choice architectures. The

necro-maternal economy names extraction from social reproduction under the sign of family. The *sororal strike* names the counter-figure to Rand's strike of the mind, connecting the Wages for Housework campaign and the Icelandic women's strike of 1975 to the climax of a videogame.

For the debate over humanism, it argues that Rapture demonstrates the failure of a possessive humanism, not of humanism as such, and it assembles from Beauvoir, Weil, Arendt, Haraway and Wynter the outline of a relational humanism in which obligations to the vulnerable precede the rights of the strong, and which acknowledges, rather than forgets, humanism's entanglement in the eugenic project.

For the ethics of representation, it identifies in the Little Sisters an *engineered hermeneutical injustice*, a conditioning that supplies victims only their exploiters' concepts, and it reads the game's concealment of what is done to them as a double bind between restraint and complicity. Following Spivak, Fricker and Hartman, it argues that the critic's obligation is to make the structure of harm legible without restaging the harm or inventing a voice for those the record silences, and it locates the girls' one act of testimony where the game places it.

Methodologically, it shows that the historical constellation of 1944 to 1963 can serve game criticism as a disciplined way of reading a fictional world against the intellectual history it impersonates.

Limitations

The thesis treats race less fully than the material warrants. Rapture is overwhelmingly white; its principal Asian character, Suchong, is drawn from orientalist stereotype (Said 1978); and *Infinite*'s explicit engagement with race remains contested. A disability-studies reading has been developed only in relation to the eugenic continuum and the game's horror aesthetic, and deserves fuller treatment. Authorship is collective, and claims about intention have been bracketed throughout. Paraphrastic citation trades the precision of quotation for interpretive independence; a fuller study would draw on licensed scripts and development archives. Players' experiences differ, and empirical reception studies would test claims made here about "the player." Finally, a constellational method can find patterns anywhere. Each connection has been anchored in the game's nomenclature, mechanics or plot, and resonances such as Diane McClintock's surname or Rosalind Lutece's given name should be weighed as resonances, not as claims of design.

Future Research

Three lines of inquiry follow. The first is comparative: the courteous imperative in other games organized around a guiding voice, among them *Portal* (Valve, 2007), *Spec Ops: The Line* (Yager Development, 2012) and *The Stanley Parable* (Galactic Cafe, 2013). The second is practical: whether a reward system can represent unrewarded virtue, and what designs in which mercy is genuinely costly would teach. The third is political: real-world projects of libertarian exit, from seasteading to the charter-city movement, read through the city that anatomized them before they began (Thiel 2009).

Final Word

Ryan's banner left room for one word, Man. The game's structure keeps returning to the people that word left out: the girls who produced the city's wealth, the men welded into its armour, the women who restored its life, the son who was manufactured to end it. The sororal humanism this thesis has traced is, finally, the decision to count them.

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KEYWORDS

BioShock · *Ken Levine* · *Irrational Games* · *game studies* · *Ayn Rand* · *Objectivism* · *Atlas Shrugged* · *possessive individualism* · *self-ownership* · *neoliberalism* · *Mont Pèlerin Society* · *libertarian paternalism* · *parasitism* · *Michel Serres* · *social reproduction* · *feminist political economy* · *Wages for Housework* · *the sexual contract* · *Carole Pateman* · *consent* · *speech act theory* · *indirect speech acts* · *interpellation* · *courteous imperative* · *brainwashing* · *behaviourism* · *acousmatic voice* · *masculinist protection* · *ethics of care* · *maternal thinking* · *Simone de Beauvoir* · *feminist utopia* · *dystopia* · *biopolitics* · *human capital* · *necropolitics* · *bare life* · *dialectic of enlightenment* · *economic theology* · *humanism* · *existentialism* · *natality* · *enhancement ethics* · *transhumanism* · *posthumanism* · *cyborg* · *Sylvia Wynter* · *procedural rhetoric* · *ludonarrative dissonance* · *ludic Objectivism* · *player agency* · *moral choice systems* · *blue humanities* · *sororal strike*